

Degree Project in Industrial Economics and Management

Second cycle, 30 credits

Communication as Organizational Capability in Consultancy Firms

A Comparative Case Study of Professional Autonomy and Organizational Consolidation in Swedish IT Consulting

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TRITA-ITM-EX 2026:553
Stockholm, Sweden 2026

www.kth.se

Master of Science Thesis TRITA-ITM-EX 2026:553

Industrial economics and management

Communication as Organizational Capability in Consultancy Firms: A Comparative Case Study of Professional Autonomy and Organizational Consolidation in Swedish IT Consulting

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Abstract

Consultancy firms depend on communication to translate expertise, coordinate knowledge work, build client trust and represent the organization. Yet communication is often treated as an individual consultant skill rather than as an organizational capability. This creates a theoretical problem: consultancy work requires professional autonomy and situated judgement, while organizational capability depends on practices becoming structured, collectively enacted, reinforced and recognized beyond individuals.

This thesis examines how communication becomes, or fails to become, an organizational capability in Swedish technology and digital consulting firms. Drawing on organizational capability theory, the study uses a qualitative multiple case design based on ten semi-structured interviews with consultants, managers and leadership representatives from Knowit, Netlight and Adage.

The findings show that communication is strategically central but unevenly consolidated. It is structured through firm routines, client project practices and individual judgement, and reinforced through networks, managers, feedback and experience. Communication is recognized through effects such as trust, delivery outcomes, feedback and breakdowns rather than formal metrics. Digital tools and AI increase speed, access and visibility, but do not automatically create shared capability. The thesis contributes by conceptualizing communication capability as a paradox between professional autonomy and organizational consolidation.

Keywords

communication capability, organizational capability, consultancy firms, professional service firms, knowledge-intensive services, professional autonomy, organizational routines, capability paradox, digital communication, artificial intelligence, cross-functional alignment

TRITA-ITM-EX 2026:553

Industriell ekonomi
och organisation

Hur kommunikation blir en organisatorisk förmåga i konsultföretag: En jämförande fallstudie av konsultföretag inom teknik och digitalisering i Sverige

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Sammanfattning

Konsultföretag är beroende av kommunikation för att översätta expertis, samordna kunskapsarbete, bygga kundförtroende och representera organizationen. Kommunikation behandlas dock ofta som en individuell konsultfärdighet snarare än som en organisatorisk förmåga. Detta skapar ett teoretiskt problem: konsultarbete kräver professionell autonomi och situationsanpassat omdöme, medan organisatorisk förmåga bygger på att praktiker blir strukturerade, kollektivt utförda, förstärkta och erkända bortom enskilda individer.

Denna studie undersöker hur kommunikation blir, eller inte blir, en organisatorisk förmåga i svenska teknik och digitalkonsultföretag. Studien utgår från teori om organisatoriska förmågor och bygger på en kvalitativ flerfallsstudie med tio semistrukturerade intervjuer med konsulter, chefer och ledningsrepresentanter från Knowit, Netlight och Adage.

Resultaten visar att kommunikation är strategiskt central men ojämnt konsoliderad. Den struktureras genom företagsrutiner, kund och projektpraktiker samt individuellt omdöme, och förstärks genom nätverk, chefer, återkoppling och erfarenhet. Kommunikation erkänns främst genom effekter såsom förtroende, leveransresultat, återkoppling och kommunikationsproblem snarare än genom formella mätetal. Digitala verktyg och AI ökar hastighet, tillgänglighet och synlighet, men skapar inte automatiskt gemensam organisatorisk förmåga. Studien bidrar genom att förstå kommunikationsförmåga som en paradox mellan professionell autonomi och organisatorisk konsolidering.

Nyckelord

kommunikationsförmåga, organisatorisk förmåga, konsultföretag, professionella tjänsteföretag, kunskapsintensiva tjänster, professionell autonomi, organisatoriska rutiner, förmågeparadox, digital kommunikation, artificiell intelligens, tvärfunktionell samordning

Acknowledgement

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to my academic supervisor, Johann Packendorff, for his guidance, thoughtful feedback and encouragement throughout this thesis process. His support helped me strengthen my work and stay motivated during the most demanding stages of the work. I would also like to thank my examiner, Mana Farshid, for her valuable feedback and guidance in this journey, which helped me improve the quality and direction of the thesis.

I am especially grateful to Knowit Connectivity AB for giving me the opportunity to conduct this thesis in collaboration with the organization. My heartfelt thanks go to Irfan Khalid, David Blaag-Nilsson and Fredrik Edlund Oldenburg for their constant guidance, motivation and everyday support. Their openness, time and practical insights helped me understand the organizational context more deeply and made this thesis journey both meaningful and enjoyable.

I would also like to thank all the interview participants from Knowit, Netlight and Adage who generously shared their experiences and reflections. Their openness and willingness to speak about their work were essential to the development of this study.

I am deeply thankful to KTH for giving me the opportunity to study, learn and grow in such an inspiring environment. I would also like to thank the wonderful people I met during my time at KTH, especially the friends who became like family. Their encouragement, humor and support kept me motivated and made this journey unforgettable.

A special thank you goes to my closest friends back home, Ishita Agarwal, Khushi Mundra and Anamitra Bhar, and my sister, Rudraa Sengupta, for always being a source of hope, strength and motivation, especially during challenging moments at my study abroad. Their support has meant more than words can express.

Lastly, I would like to thank all my professors, friends and family for their unwavering support throughout my studies. Your belief in me has been a constant source of motivation.

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1. Introduction

Consultancy firms operate in knowledge-intensive environments where value is created primarily through expertise, interpretation, problem solving and credibility rather than through tangible products (Grant, 1996; von Nordenflycht, 2010). In such firms, communication is not a peripheral support activity. It is central to how expertise is translated, how client problems are framed, how trust is built and how work is coordinated across organizational and client boundaries.

This makes communication strategically important, but also theoretically difficult to locate. Consultancy firms depend heavily on individual consultants' expertise, judgement and client-facing autonomy. At the same time, organizational capability theory argues that sustained organizational performance depends on abilities that are not merely individual, but structured, repeatable and collectively enacted through organizational routines and arrangements (Nelson and Winter, 1982; Winter, 2003; Felin and Foss, 2005). Communication in consultancy firms therefore creates a capability paradox: it is central to value creation, yet it may remain structurally fragile because it is often enacted through individual consultants rather than consolidated at the organizational level.

This tension is particularly relevant in consultancy firms because professional work requires flexibility, adaptation and situated judgement. Consultants must adjust communication to different clients, stakeholders, projects and technical contexts. These same conditions make communication difficult to standardize or codify. As a result, communication may be performed effectively by skilled individuals without becoming something the organization can consistently support, reproduce and recognize.

The issue is further intensified by digital developments. Digital platforms, collaborative tools and artificial intelligence supported systems increasingly shape how consultants communicate, document knowledge, coordinate internally and interact with clients (Leonardi, 2011; Raisch and Krakowski, 2021; Huang and Rust, 2021). These tools may make communication faster, more visible and easier to support, but they do not automatically create organizational capability. Communication still depends on judgement, shared routines, organizational attention and alignment across people and functions.

This study examines how communication becomes, or fails to become, organizational capability in consultancy firms. Empirically, the study focuses on three consultancy firms operating in technology and digital advisory contexts: Knowit, Netlight and Adage. Knowit operates primarily within digital transformation and IT consulting, Netlight focuses on technology consulting and software development, and Adage specializes in data engineering and technical consulting. These firms provide a relevant setting because their work is knowledge-intensive, client-facing and dependent on consultants' ability to translate technical expertise into meaningful communication.

1.1 Problematization

Consultancy firms are strongly client-centric organizations. Their value is created not only through technical expertise, but through the ability to understand client problems, translate specialized knowledge, coordinate stakeholders and build trust across organizational boundaries. Communication is therefore not a secondary support activity in consultancy work. It is part of how expertise becomes valuable to the client.

At the same time, the very conditions that make communication important in consultancy firms also make it difficult to organize. Consultants often work in different client environments, follow client-specific routines, manage their own stakeholder relationships and adapt their communication to different projects, roles and technical contexts. Communication therefore tends to be shaped by individual consultant judgement; client demands and local project practices rather than by one shared

organizational system. This creates fragmentation in how communication is performed, learned, documented and recognized across the firm.

This fragmentation matters because communication is central to consultancy performance. If communication remains dependent mainly on individual consultants, the organization may benefit from strong communicators without necessarily developing communication as something the firm can consistently support, reproduce and improve. Knowledge may stay with individuals, client routines may dominate internal routines, and lessons from communication successes or failures may not become organizational learning. In this sense, communication can be strategically essential while remaining structurally weak.

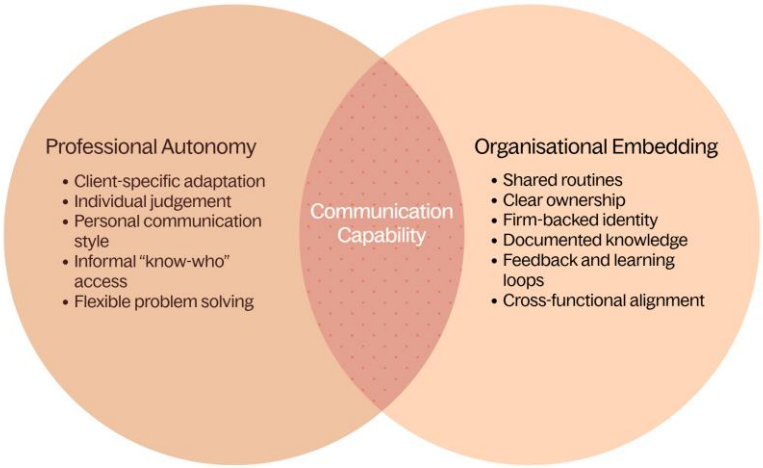


Figure 1. Communication capability tension in client-centric consultancy work

The theoretical problem addressed in this study is the gap between communication's strategic importance and its limited conceptualization as an organizational capability. Communication research emphasizes its role in reputation, identity, stakeholder relationships, legitimacy and coordination, yet often treats communication as a function, role or individual competence rather than as a collectively sustained organizational ability (Cornelissen, 2020; van Riel and Fombrun, 2007; Hallahan et al., 2007).

This distinction is especially relevant in consultancy firms. Organizational capability theory argues that capabilities must be structured, collectively enacted and reinforced beyond individual actors (Winter, 2003; Felin and Foss, 2005), while consultancy communication depends on professional autonomy, client adaptation and situated judgement (see Figure 1). The problem is not whether communication matters, but how it can become organizationally supported without undermining the flexibility consultancy work requires.

This thesis addresses that problem by examining how communication is structured, collectively enacted, reinforced, recognized and shaped by digital tools across consultancy firms. The central tension is that communication must remain adaptable to clients and situations, while also becoming sufficiently embedded in organizational routines, learning mechanisms and shared practices to function as an organizational capability.

1.2 Purpose and Research Questions

The purpose of this thesis is to examine how communication becomes organizational capability in consultancy firms. More specifically, the study investigates how communication moves from being dependent on individual consultants' expertise, judgement and client relationships toward becoming structured and reinforced at the organizational level.

The study contributes to the intersection of organizational capability theory, communication research and professional service firm literature. Organizational capability theory explains how organizations develop structured and collectively sustained abilities, but it has rarely been applied to communication as a distinct organizational phenomenon. Communication research recognizes communication as strategically important, but often frames it as a function, professional activity or evaluative challenge rather than as a capability embedded in organizational routines. Research on consultancy firms highlights expertise, reputation and client relationships, but pays less attention to how communication practices consolidate structurally within such firms.

Accordingly, this study is guided by the following research questions:

1. **RQ1:** How is communication capability constituted and developed in consultancy firms?
2. **RQ2:** How is communication capability recognized and valued within consultancy firms, and how do digital developments shape this recognition?

1.3 Sustainability

In accordance with the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (United Nations, n.d.), this thesis contributes primarily to the social and economic dimensions of sustainability. The study does not address environmental sustainability directly. Instead, its contribution lies in understanding how communication practices in consultancy firms can support more sustainable knowledge work, reduce organizational fragmentation, improve learning, and strengthen coordination in digitally evolving work environments.

The thesis is particularly connected to the following SDG targets:

- Target 4.4: Quality education and relevant skills

  Communication capability is closely connected to learning and professional development. The findings show that consultants often learn communication through experience, feedback, observation, mentoring, and client exposure. By analyzing how such learning can become more organizationally supported, the thesis contributes to the development of relevant professional skills for knowledge workers, including communication, coordination, digital collaboration, and stakeholder management.

- Target 8.2: Decent work and economic growth through productivity and innovation

  In consultancy firms, communication affects project delivery, client trust, knowledge sharing, and cross-functional alignment. Stronger communication capability can reduce rework, duplicated effort, misalignment, and dependency on individual knowledge holders. In this way, the thesis contributes to understanding how knowledge-intensive firms can improve productivity and sustain value creation through better organizational communication practices.

- Target 8.3: Productive activities, entrepreneurship, and growth of knowledge-intensive firms

  Consultancy firms, particularly smaller and growing firms, often depend on informal communication, direct access to experts, and individual consultants' judgement. As firms grow, these practices may become fragile if they are not supported by shared routines and organizational learning mechanisms. By analyzing how communication can move from individual competence toward organizational capability, this thesis offers insights relevant to the sustainable development and growth of knowledge-intensive service firms.



Figure 2. UN Sustainable Development Goals relevant to the study (United Nations, n.d.)

Overall, the sustainability contribution of this thesis lies in showing how better communication capability can support healthier, more inclusive, and more productive knowledge work. In consultancy firms, where employees often operate across organizational boundaries, improved communication structures can reduce ambiguity, support newcomer integration, strengthen learning, and improve coordination between individuals, teams, clients, and leadership.

1.4 Thesis Structure

The thesis is structured as follows. Chapter 2 develops the theoretical framework by reviewing organizational capability theory, communication research, professional service firm literature, recognition and legitimacy, and digital evolution. Chapter 3 presents the methodology, including the multiple case study design, interview approach and coding process. Chapter 4 outlines the contributions and analytical implications of the study. Chapter 5 presents the empirical findings across the three consultancy firms. Chapter 6 discusses the findings in relation to the research questions and the theoretical framework. Chapter 7 concludes the thesis by summarizing the contribution, practical implications, limitations and directions for future research. The final sections contain the reference list, AI use disclosure and appendices.

2. Theoretical Framework and Literature Review

This chapter develops the theoretical basis for analyzing communication as an organizational capability in consultancy firms. It brings together organizational capability theory, communication research, professional service firm literature, recognition and legitimacy, and digital evolution. The purpose is not only to show that communication matters, but to clarify why communication becomes theoretically problematic in consultancy firms. The chapter argues that communication is central to consultancy value creation, yet difficult to consolidate organizationally because consultancy work depends on professional autonomy, individual expertise and client-specific adaptation.

2.1 Organizational Capability as Analytical Lens

Organizational capability theory provides the main analytical lens for this thesis because it distinguishes between what individuals can do and what organizations can reliably reproduce. The resource-based view argues that firms differ in performance because they possess and deploy valuable resources in different ways (Barney, 1991; Grant, 1996). However, resources alone do not explain sustained organizational performance. Capabilities refer to the coordinated deployment of resources through patterned organizational processes, which means that they are not reducible to isolated individual skills or assets (Grant, 1996; Winter, 2003).

This distinction is central to the present study. If communication is only understood as something individual consultants do well, then it remains an individual competence. For communication to be analyzed as organizational capability, it must be examined as a recurrent, collectively supported and structurally embedded practice. Capability theory therefore shifts the analytical question from whether communication is important to whether communication is organized in ways that allow the firm to reproduce, support and improve it beyond particular individuals.

Routines literature clarifies how such organizational consolidation occurs. Organizational routines are recurrent and recognizable patterns of interdependent action that support reliable performance over time (Nelson and Winter, 1982; Becker, 2004). Routines do not necessarily remove flexibility. Rather, they provide a stabilizing structure within which actors can coordinate their actions while still adapting to specific situations (Pentland and Feldman, 2005). This matters for communication because consultancy communication cannot be reduced to scripts or fixed templates. It requires judgement and adaptation, but it may still depend on underlying routines, shared expectations, feedback practices and organizational support.

The micro foundations perspective further strengthens this distinction by showing that individuals contribute to capabilities without fully explaining them (Felin and Foss, 2005; Felin, Foss and Ployhart, 2015). Capabilities emerge when individual knowledge and action are integrated into collective processes, role structures and coordination mechanisms. Without such integration, organizational performance remains dependent on variation across individuals and contexts (Winter, 2003; Zollo and Winter, 2002). This is especially relevant for communication, since communication often appears through individual style, judgement and relational skill, while the question of organizational capability concerns whether such practices are supported and stabilized by the firm.

Dynamic capabilities research adds that firms must adapt their capabilities as environments change (Teece, Pisano and Shuen, 1997; Teece, 2007). However, even adaptation depends on routines, learning and organizational reinforcement (Zollo and Winter, 2002). Digital and market changes may reshape how communication is enacted, but they do not remove the need for coordination and structural integration (Leonardi, 2011). From this perspective, communication capability can be analyzed by

examining whether communication practices are structurally integrated, collectively enacted and reinforced over time.

The implication for this thesis is that communication cannot be treated as organizational capability simply because it is important. It becomes analytically meaningful as capability only if it shows some degree of routinization, collective enactment, reinforcement and organizational recognition. This provides the theoretical standard against which communication practices in consultancy firms can be examined.

2.2 Conceptualizing Communication Capability

Communication research consistently positions communication as central to organizational functioning. Corporate communication research highlights communication's role in organizational identity, reputation, stakeholder relationships and legitimacy (Cornelissen, 2020; van Riel and Fombrun, 2007). Strategic communication research frames communication as purposeful organizational action directed toward achieving organizational goals and aligning internal and external stakeholders (Hallahan et al., 2007). Internal communication research further emphasizes communication as a mechanism for coordination, sensemaking and knowledge sharing across organizational units (Zerfass and Franke, 2013; Macnamara, 2018).

These perspectives demonstrate that communication is strategically important, but they do not fully explain when communication becomes an organizational capability. Much of the communication literature treats communication as a function, professional role, managerial activity or evaluative challenge. Communication is often associated with communication departments, communication managers, stakeholder engagement, branding or internal communication processes (Moss, Newman and DeSanto, 2005). Other studies focus on demonstrating communication value through measurement, return on investment or evaluation frameworks (Meng and Berger, 2012; Zerfass, Verčič and Volk, 2017). These approaches are useful, but they often analyze communication through outputs, roles or performance indicators rather than through the organizational conditions that make communication reproducible.

This creates a conceptual asymmetry. Communication is widely acknowledged as strategically significant, but it is rarely examined through the theoretical lens that explains how strategically significant activities become organizational capabilities. Organizational capability theory emphasizes routinization, collective enactment, structural integration and reinforcement (Winter, 2003; Felin and Foss, 2005). Communication research, by contrast, often focuses on whether communication works, how it is managed, or how its value can be measured. The missing question is whether communication becomes embedded in organizational routines and structures, or whether it remains dependent on individual communicative competence.

Conceptualizing communication capability therefore requires a shift in analytical focus. The relevant issue is not only whether communication is effective, persuasive or strategically aligned. The stronger question is whether communication is something the organization can repeatedly support, reproduce and recognize across consultants, projects and client contexts. This reframing makes it possible to study communication not only as a functional activity, but as a potential organizational capability.

This shift is particularly important because communication has both visible and invisible dimensions. Visible dimensions include presentations, meetings, templates, channels and communication materials. Less visible dimensions include judgement, tone, audience adaptation, trust building, timing, escalation, interpretation and alignment. These less visible dimensions may be central to consultancy value creation,

but they are also harder to standardize or evaluate. This makes communication a theoretically interesting case for organizational capability analysis.

2.3 Communication in Consultancy Firms: The Challenge of Structural Consolidation

Consultancy firms provide a particularly relevant context for studying communication capability because they are knowledge-intensive, client-facing and strongly dependent on professional autonomy. Professional service firms rely on expert knowledge, credibility and client trust rather than on standardized physical products (von Nordenflycht, 2010). In such firms, value is created through the interpretation of client problems, the articulation of expertise and the ability to persuade clients that proposed solutions are credible and useful (Greenwood et al., 2005; Maister, 1993). These processes are fundamentally communicative.

At the same time, the organizational conditions of consultancy firms make communication difficult to consolidate. Consultants often work in dispersed client environments, interact with different stakeholder groups and adapt their communication style to project specific conditions. Professional service firm research emphasizes that consultants exercise considerable discretion in how they interpret problems, construct solutions and interact with clients (Maister, 1993; Empson, 2001). This discretion is necessary because consultancy work often involves ambiguity, incomplete information and client-specific judgement.

However, the same autonomy that enables effective consultancy work can also weaken organizational consolidation. If each consultant develops their own communication style, client management approach and knowledge sharing habits, communication may remain fragmented across individuals and projects. The firm may benefit from strong communicators, but it may struggle to develop communication as a capability that persists beyond particular people. This is the central structural challenge of communication in consultancy firms.

Professional and institutional logics literature helps explain this tension. Professional service firms are shaped by logics of expertise, autonomy and professional judgement, while organizational consolidation requires coordination, standardization and structural reinforcement (Thornton, Ocasio and Lounsbury, 2012). These logics are not simply opposites. They coexist in consultancy work. Consultants need autonomy to adapt to clients, but the firm also needs shared practices to sustain reputation, coordinate knowledge and present a coherent organizational identity (Suddaby and Viale, 2011).

From an organizational capability perspective, this creates a critical empirical problem. Capability theory suggests that organizational abilities must persist beyond individual actors and become embedded in collective patterns of action (Winter, 2003). Consultancy firms, however, often rely on individual professionals whose work is client embedded and context dependent. Communication therefore becomes a useful site for examining how professional autonomy and organizational consolidation interact.

The issue is not whether consultancy firms should fully standardize communication. Full standardization may be inappropriate because consultancy communication depends on situational judgement and adaptation. The issue is rather how communication can become sufficiently structured, shared and reinforced without undermining the professional autonomy that makes consultancy work valuable. This tension positions consultancy firms as a theoretically rich context for studying communication capability.

2.4 Recognition, Legitimacy, and Organizational Attention

Structural integration alone does not guarantee that communication becomes organizational capability. For a practice to stabilize, it must also gain recognition, legitimacy and organizational attention. Institutional theory suggests that practices become stable when perceived as legitimate and aligned with dominant expectations (Suchman, 1995; Meyer and Rowan, 1977). Without legitimacy, communication may remain peripheral even when it contributes to organizational performance.

This is especially relevant because communication value is often indirect. It can influence trust, client satisfaction, project progress, employee alignment and organizational reputation, but these outcomes are difficult to isolate and measure. Research on intangible capabilities and communication evaluation similarly shows that relational contributions are often difficult to assess (Ambrosini, Bowman and Collier, 2009; Meng and Berger, 2012; Zerfass, Verčič and Volk, 2017; Zerfass and Volk, 2018).

Recognition is therefore not secondary. It is part of how communication becomes organizationally reinforced. Organizational attention shapes which issues receive resources, leadership focus and repeated investment (Ocasio, 1997). If communication is treated mainly as a support function, interpersonal skill or something that "good consultants just do", it may remain important in practice but weakly institutionalized.

From a capability perspective, recognition matters because capabilities develop through repeated reinforcement and learning (Zollo and Winter, 2002). Communication practices that are discussed, evaluated or recognized through feedback, training, leadership attention or client outcomes are more likely to be improved and reinforced. This makes recognition and legitimacy central to the second research question.

The analytical implication is that communication capability must be studied not only by identifying routines, but also by examining how communication becomes visible. It may become visible through formal evaluation, but also through trust, feedback, project success, confusion, rework or client perception. These forms of recognition shape whether communication remains an implicit skill or becomes an acknowledged organizational capability.

2.5 Digital Evolution as Contextual Intensifier

Digital evolution reshapes how communication practices are enacted, but it does not remove the organizational capability problem. Digital tools, collaborative platforms and AI-supported systems increasingly mediate how consultants share information, document knowledge, organize meetings and coordinate across client and organizational boundaries.

Sociomaterial and technology-in-practice perspectives emphasize that technologies do not act independently of organizational routines. They become meaningful through use and through interaction with human action, organizational norms and existing practices (Orlikowski, 2007; Leonardi, 2011). Technological artefacts can enable or constrain communication, but their effects depend on how they are embedded in organizational practice (Barley, 1986). Digital tools can therefore support communication without necessarily creating communication capability.

AI-supported systems further complicate this issue. AI may help consultants draft messages, summarize information, prepare presentations or structure ideas more efficiently (Davenport and Kirby, 2016). Research on AI in service and management suggests that automation often augments rather than replaces human capabilities (Huang and Rust, 2021; Raisch and Krakowski, 2021). However, relational judgement, stakeholder interpretation and credibility building remain dependent on human and organizational practices.

Digital technologies also increase visibility and traceability. Digital communication leaves records, produces data trails and makes some work more observable (Yoo, Henfridsson and Lyytinen, 2010). This may increase expectations that communication can be evaluated and managed more systematically, but visibility does not automatically create legitimacy or capability. Communication may become more traceable without becoming more meaningful, coherent or organizationally reinforced.

From a capability perspective, digital evolution creates dual pressure. Digital tools may support structural integration by embedding templates, workflows, channels and records into organizational systems (Leonardi, 2011). At the same time, they may intensify fragmentation when teams, clients or consultants rely on different platforms, expectations and communication habits. This study therefore treats digital evolution as a contextual intensifier: it makes communication faster, more visible and more technologically supported, while intensifying the question of how communication capability becomes structured, reinforced and recognized.

2.6 Synthesis: The Capability Paradox

The reviewed literature establishes four important points. First, organizational capability theory shows that capabilities require more than individual skill. They depend on recurrent, collective and reinforced patterns of action (Nelson and Winter, 1982; Winter, 2003; Felin and Foss, 2005). Second, communication research shows that communication is strategically important for identity, reputation, coordination and stakeholder relations, but tends to treat communication as function, role, activity or evaluative challenge rather than capability (Cornelissen, 2020; Hallahan et al., 2007; Meng and Berger, 2012). Third, professional service firm literature shows that consultancy firms depend on expert autonomy, client judgement and credibility, which makes communication central but difficult to standardize (Maister, 1993; Greenwood et al., 2005; von Nordenflycht, 2010). Fourth, recognition and digital evolution shape whether communication becomes visible, reinforced and supported within organizations (Suchman, 1995; Ocasio, 1997; Leonardi, 2011; Huang and Rust, 2021).

Taken together, this creates the capability paradox at the center of the study. Communication is central to value creation, but it may remain structurally fragile as organizational capability. The communicative practices that make consultants effective may be precisely the practices that are hardest to standardize, codify or reproduce. Professional autonomy enables flexibility and client responsiveness, but it can also prevent communication from becoming organizationally consolidated.

Paradox theory suggests that such tensions are not necessarily temporary problems that can be solved once and for all. They may be persistent conditions that organizations must manage because both sides are necessary (Smith and Lewis, 2011). In this study, professional autonomy and organizational consolidation are both necessary. Consultancy communication must remain flexible enough to adapt to clients, contexts and expertise. At the same time, it must become sufficiently structured, shared, reinforced and recognized to exist beyond individual consultants.

The literature therefore points to a theoretical puzzle rather than a simple gap. Communication is recognized as important, but importance alone does not make it a capability. Capability formation requires structural integration, collective enactment, institutional reinforcement and recognition. Consultancy firms provide a setting where these requirements are difficult to achieve because communication is deeply tied to individual judgement and client embedded work. This paradox provides the foundation for the conceptual framework.

Table 1. Literature synthesis and analytical gap

Literature stream	What the literature explains	What remains unresolved for this thesis
Organizational capability theory	Capabilities depend on routines, collective action, reinforcement and organizational integration.	It does not fully explain how communication, as a relational and interpretive practice, becomes organizational capability.
Communication research	Communication is central to identity, reputation, coordination, stakeholder relations and evaluation.	It often treats communication as a function, role, activity or output rather than as a structurally consolidated capability.
Professional service firm literature	Consultancy firms rely on expertise, credibility, autonomy and client judgement.	It does not fully explain how communication practices move from individual professional competence to organizational capability.
Recognition and legitimacy literature	Practices stabilize when they receive legitimacy, attention and reinforcement.	It does not fully explain how communication becomes recognized when its value is indirect, relational and difficult to measure.
Digital evolution literature	Digital tools reshape routines, visibility, coordination and human technological work.	It does not determine whether digital communication practices become organizational capability or remain individual tool use.

The unresolved issue is therefore not whether communication matters in consultancy firms. The unresolved issue is how communication becomes organizationally consolidated in a context where professional autonomy, client-specific adaptation and dispersed knowledge work make consolidation difficult. This thesis addresses that gap by examining communication capability through five interrelated dimensions.

2.7 Conceptual Framework

Drawing on the preceding literature, communication capability in consultancy firms is conceptualized as a potential organizational ability shaped by five interrelated dimensions: structural integration, collective enactment, institutional reinforcement, recognition and legitimacy, and digital contextual influence. These dimensions do not represent a maturity score or diagnostic checklist. They are analytical categories used to examine how communication practices become organizationally embedded, as summarized in Table 2.

First, communication capability requires structural integration. This refers to the extent to which communication practices are embedded in organizational routines, workflows, templates, roles and processes rather than remaining dependent only on individual judgement. Capability theory suggests that organizational abilities require stable and repeatable patterns of action (Winter, 2003; Felin and Foss, 2005). Structural integration therefore captures whether communication has an organizational form.

Second, communication capability requires collective enactment. Capabilities are not enacted by isolated individuals, but through coordinated action across organizational actors (Nelson and Winter, 1982; Pentland and Feldman, 2005). In consultancy firms, this dimension captures whether communication is shared across teams, client interfaces, managers, consultants and internal support structures, or whether it remains fragmented across individuals and projects.

Third, communication capability depends on institutional reinforcement. Practices become more stable when they are supported through learning, feedback, training, leadership attention and repeated improvement (Zollo and Winter, 2002). This dimension captures whether communication is actively

developed and reproduced over time, or whether consultants are expected to learn it mainly through experience.

Fourth, communication capability requires recognition and legitimacy. Practices that are not recognized as strategically important may remain underdeveloped, even when they are practically important (Suchman, 1995; Ocasio, 1997). This dimension captures how communication is valued, evaluated and made visible within the organization.

Fifth, communication capability is shaped by digital contextual influence. Digital platforms and AI-supported tools affect how communication is structured, documented, accelerated and evaluated (Leonardi, 2011; Huang and Rust, 2021). This dimension captures how digital tools support or complicates the consolidation of communication capability.

Table 2. Analytical framework for communication capability

Framework dimension	Theoretical basis	Analytical focus in this study
Structural integration	Capabilities depend on routines, structures and coordinated organizational arrangements (Winter, 2003; Felin and Foss, 2005).	Whether communication practices are embedded in templates, workflows, roles, documentation or recurring routines.
Collective enactment	Capabilities are collectively enacted rather than individually held (Nelson and Winter, 1982; Pentland and Feldman, 2005).	Whether communication is shared across consultants, teams, functions and client interfaces.
Institutional reinforcement	Capabilities develop through learning, feedback and reinforcement over time (Zollo and Winter, 2002).	Whether communication practices are supported through training, mentoring, feedback, leadership attention or learning mechanisms.
Recognition and legitimacy	Organizational practices stabilize when they receive attention and legitimacy (Suchman, 1995; Ocasio, 1997).	Whether communication is recognized, evaluated or valued as part of organizational performance.
Digital contextual influence	Technologies shape routines and redistribute tasks between human and digital systems (Leonardi, 2011; Huang and Rust, 2021).	Whether digital tools and AI support, fragment or intensify communication practices.

Together, these dimensions form the analytical framework used in empirical study. The framework does not assume that communication capability already exists in the studied firms. Instead, it provides a structure for examining where communication is supported, where it remains individualized, and how the tension between professional autonomy and organizational consolidation appears in practice.

The framework directly supports the research questions. RQ1 is addressed by examining how communication capability is constituted and developed through structural integration, collective enactment and institutional reinforcement. RQ2 is addressed by examining how communication capability is recognized and valued, and how digital developments shape this recognition. The empirical analysis therefore uses the framework as an analytical lens for comparing how communication becomes, or fails to become, organizational capability across consultancy firms.

3. Methodology

This chapter explains the methodological approach used to examine how communication becomes organizational capability in consultancy firms. The study follows a qualitative multiple case study design based on semi-structured interviews with consultants, managers and leadership representatives across three consultancy firms. The chapter describes research design, case selection, data collection, data analysis, and measures taken to support trustworthiness, reflexivity and ethical integrity.

3.1 Research Design

This study adopts a qualitative multiple case study design to explore how communication capability is structured, reinforced and recognized within consultancy firms. A qualitative approach is suitable because communication capability is a complex organizational phenomenon involving routines, practices, perceptions, informal norms, digital tools and structural arrangements that cannot be fully captured through quantitative measures alone (Shah and Corley, 2006).

The study is theory informed rather than purely inductive. Organizational capability theory provides the primary analytical lens, while the conceptual framework developed in Chapter 2 guides the examination of communication through five dimensions: structural integration, collective enactment, institutional reinforcement, recognition and legitimacy, and digital contextual influence. This enabled the study to remain theoretically focused while still allowing empirical patterns to emerge from participants' descriptions of everyday communication practices.

A multiple case design was used to strengthen analytical comparison across consultancy contexts (Eisenhardt, 1989; Goffin et al., 2019). The purpose was not to produce statistically generalizable findings, but to compare how communication capability appears across firms that share a knowledge-intensive and client-facing consultancy context while differing in size, structure, routines and degree of formalization. This design allowed the analysis to identify both recurring patterns and case specific configurations. The multiple case design supports analytical rather than statistical generalization, allowing theoretical insight to be developed through comparison across rich empirical settings (Eisenhardt and Graebner, 2007; Yin, 2018).

3.2 Case Selection and Sampling

The study focuses on three consultancy firms operating in knowledge-intensive technology and digital advisory contexts: Knowit, Netlight and Adage. Knowit operates primarily within digital transformation and IT consulting, Netlight focuses on technology consulting and software development, and Adage specializes in data engineering and technical consulting. These firms were selected because their work depends heavily on expertise articulation, client interaction, technical problem solving and digitally mediated communication. This makes them suitable settings for examining how communication practices between individual consultant competence, client project routines and organizational capability.

The cases were selected through purposive sampling based on their relevance to the research problem. All three firms rely on consultants' ability to translate expertise into client relevant communication, while also needing to coordinate knowledge internally. The firms therefore offer comparable but distinct contexts for analyzing communication capability.

Participants were informed that the study would identify the participating organizations (Knowit, Netlight, and Adage), while individual participants would remain anonymous.

Table 3. Case overview

Firm	Consultancy domain	Relevance to the study
Knowit	Digital transformation and IT consulting	Primary case with access to consultants, managers and leadership perspectives. Relevant for examining communication across organizational levels and client embedded work.
Netlight	Technology consulting and software development	Comparative case with strong emphasis on consultant networks, mentoring, delivery coaching and internal community-based support.
Adage	Data engineering and technical consulting	Comparative case represents a smaller consultancy context where communication is closely tied to direct contact, expert access and growth-related structuring challenges.

Participants were selected to capture different organizational perspectives on communication capability. The sample includes consultants involved in client delivery, managers responsible for consultant support and coordination, and senior or leadership perspectives where available. This variation was important because communication capability is not located only in individual client interactions, but also in managerial support, internal alignment, formal artefacts, digital tools and organizational recognition.

In total, ten semi-structured interviews were conducted across the three cases, including consultants, managers and leadership representatives. This sample enabled comparison across delivery, managerial and leadership perspectives on communication capability.

3.3 Data Collection

Data was collected through semi-structured interviews, which were appropriate for exploring communication as a practice based organizational phenomenon. Since the study examines routines, coordination, learning, recognition, digital tools and professional judgement, interviews allowed participants to describe how communication appears in their day-to-day work while still giving the researcher flexibility to ask follow-up questions when new themes emerged (Kvale and Brinkmann, 2009).

The interview guide was developed from the conceptual framework presented in Chapter 2 and was designed to translate the five analytical dimensions into concrete, experience-based questions. This was important because respondents were not expected to think in theoretical terms such as “organizational capability” or “structural integration”. Instead, the questions asked about practical situations: how communication is organized, what routines and tools are used, how people coordinate, how communication is learned, when it is evaluated, and how digital tools shape expectations. In this way, the interview guide created empirical access to the framework without forcing participants to use the language of the framework.

The questions were also shaped by the empirical context of consultancy firms. Consultancy work is knowledge-intensive, client-facing and often distributed across assignments, which means communication may be influenced simultaneously by the consultancy firm, the client organization and the individual consultant. For this reason, the guide included questions about both internal and external communication, including project work, client interaction, team coordination, documentation, organizational identity and digital tools. This made it possible to examine whether communication remained dependent on individual consultants or whether it was supported through organizational routines, structures and reinforcement mechanisms.

The same core guide was used across interviews to ensure comparability, but the semi-structured format allowed the order and depth of questions to vary depending on the participant's role and responses. For example, consultants were often asked more about client work, project routines and day-to-day coordination, while managers and leadership respondents were asked more about feedback, onboarding, internal alignment and organizational communication. As the interviews progressed, follow-up probes were used more deliberately around documentation practices, cross-functional alignment and the relationship between individual consultants and organizational representation, since these areas emerged as important for understanding the capability paradox.

Table 4 summarizes how the interview guide was operationalized. The table does not imply that each interview question belonged to only one theoretical category. Rather, it shows how the question areas were designed to generate empirical material that could later be coded inductively and interpreted through the framework.

Table 4. Operationalization of the interview guide

Interview focus	Framework connection	Purpose in the study
Role, work context and project walkthrough	Background across all dimensions	To understand the respondent's role and how communication appears in concrete consultancy work.
Routines, templates, tools and documentation	Structural integration	To examine whether communication is supported by shared structures, artefacts and routines, or whether it remains dependent on individuals or client systems.
Coordination across teams, roles and functions	Collective enactment	To explore how communication is coordinated across consultants, teams, clients, sales, delivery, leadership and other organizational actors.
Learning, support and feedback	Institutional reinforcement	To understand how consultants learn what good communication looks like and whether this learning is supported formally, informally or mainly through experience.
Evaluation, visibility and organizational identity	Recognition and legitimacy	To examine how communication becomes noticed, valued or evaluated through trust, feedback, outcomes, client perception or organizational representation.
Digital tools and AI	Digital contextual influence	To understand how tools such as Teams, Slack, SharePoint and AI systems support, fragment or reshape communication practices.
Challenges and trade offs	Cross dimensional	To identify tensions between flexibility and structure, especially the tension between professional autonomy and organizational consolidation.

The full interview guide is provided in Appendix A. The guide was used as a flexible structure rather than a fixed questionnaire. This allowed the interviews to remain aligned with the research questions while still leaving space for participants to introduce examples, contradictions and emerging themes beyond the initial framework.

3.4 Data Analysis

The analysis followed a theoretically informed thematic approach (Braun and Clarke, 2006). Coding combined inductive and deductive logic. First, interview transcripts were read closely to identify inductive codes grounded in respondents' own descriptions of communication practices. These codes captured concrete empirical patterns such as documentation gaps, informal knowledge sharing, client

owned routines, manager mediated communication, feedback-based learning, AI guidance, cross-functional alignment and individual versus organizational representation.

The inductive codes were then mapped deductively to the five framework dimensions: structural integration, collective enactment, institutional reinforcement, recognition and legitimacy, and digital contextual influence. This enabled the analysis to remain grounded in the empirical material while still being structured by the conceptual framework.

Coding proceeded iteratively. An initial codebook was developed after the first interview and then refined as new interviews were analyzed. Codes were merged, renamed or adjusted when similar patterns appeared across cases. The coding process was supported by Microsoft Excel, which enabled systematic organization of interview excerpts, inductive codes, refined codes, framework dimensions, themes and cross case comparisons. The coding workbook therefore functioned as an analytical audit trail, documenting how empirical material was transformed into themes and findings.

The analysis developed through three connected stages. First, within case analysis was conducted to understand how communication practices appeared within each firm. Second, codes were compared across interviews to identify recurring themes such as selective structuring, informal reinforcement, documentation tension, recognition through effects, digital fragmentation and cross-functional alignment. Third, cross case comparison was conducted to examine how these themes appeared differently across Knowit, Netlight and Adage.

Data collection and analysis proceeded in parallel. After the initial interviews, later interviews were used not only to add empirical material, but also to assess whether new themes were emerging or whether the material was increasingly confirming existing patterns. This iterative assessment supported the evaluation of thematic saturation, understood here as the point at which additional interviews mainly deepen or confirm existing themes rather than generate substantially new analytical categories.

The final analysis did not treat the framework as a scoring tool or maturity model. Instead, the framework was used as an analytical lens for interpreting how communication practices become organizationally embedded across the three cases. An excerpt from the codebook is provided in Appendix B, and an example of the coding process is provided in Appendix C.

3.5 Validity and Reflexivity

Several measures were used to strengthen the trustworthiness of the study. Credibility was supported through the inclusion of multiple firms and different organizational roles, allowing the analysis to compare consultant, managerial and leadership perspectives. Cross case comparison strengthened the robustness of the findings by identifying patterns that appeared across firms, while also preserving case specific differences.

Dependability was supported through systematic documentation of the coding process. The Excel coding workbook recorded interview excerpts, inductive codes, refined codes, framework dimensions and themes. This created a transparent audit trail showing how empirical material was interpreted. The inclusion of a codebook excerpt and coding example in the appendix further supports transparency without overwhelming the thesis with the full workbook. Trustworthiness was supported through systematic coding, transparent documentation of analytical decisions and repeated engagement with the empirical material (Nowell et al., 2017).

Transferability was supported through detailed descriptions of the case firms, participant roles and consultancy context. The purpose of the study is not statistical generalization, but analytical generalization through theoretically informed comparison. By specifying the consultancy domains and

organizational contexts of the three firms, the thesis allows readers to assess the relevance of the findings for other knowledge-intensive consultancy settings.

Reflexivity was particularly important because the researcher had prior experience within the consultancy sector and conducted the thesis in collaboration with Knowit. This position provided advantages in terms of access, contextual understanding and familiarity with consultancy work. At the same time, it introduced a risk of insider bias, especially in interpreting communication practices within the primary case. To address this, interpretations were grounded in interview excerpts rather than personal assumptions, coding procedures were applied consistently across all firms, and cross case comparison was used to challenge case specific interpretations.

Although the study was theory informed, the interview questions were kept as concrete and practice oriented as possible. Participants were asked to describe everyday communication practices, examples, routines, challenges and experiences, rather than to classify their organization according to the theoretical framework. During the research process, the interviewer also became more attentive to the risk of over explaining the theoretical framing at the start of interviews. This was treated as a reflexive consideration, and the emphasis in later interviews was placed on descriptive questions about how communication works in practice. This helped reduce the risk of forcing respondents into theoretical categories and allowed the framework to remain the researcher's analytical tool.

Ethical considerations were addressed through voluntary participation, informed consent and anonymization of respondents. Participants were informed about the purpose of the study and gave consent for recording and transcription. Interview data were used only for thesis analysis, and identifying details were removed or generalized where necessary. Given the researcher's connection to Knowit, care was taken to avoid interviewing direct supervisors or situations where power dynamics could affect openness.

4. Contributions and Analytical Implications

4.1 Theoretical Contribution

This study contributes to organizational capability research by extending the capability perspective to the domain of communication. Organizational capability theory has been extensively applied to areas such as innovation, operational processes, and technological adaptation (Winter, 2003; Teece, 2007; Zollo and Winter, 2002). In contrast, communication scholarship has largely developed along strategic, functional, and evaluative lines (Cornelissen, 2020; Hallahan et al., 2007; Meng and Berger, 2012). While communication is widely recognized as strategically significant, the systematic integration of communication research with organizational capability theory remains limited.

By analyzing communication capability through criteria such as structural integration, collective enactment, institutional reinforcement, and recognition, this study clarifies how communication may function as an organizational capability rather than solely as a functional or professional activity. In doing so, the research contributes to bridging the conceptual separation between capability theory and communication scholarship.

The framework developed in this thesis is therefore positioned primarily as an analytical framework rather than as a managerial diagnostic tool. Its purpose is to explain how communication becomes organizationally structured, enacted, reinforced and recognized in consultancy firms. Practical implications may follow from this analysis, but the primary contribution is theoretical: extending organizational capability theory to the study of communication in knowledge-intensive professional service contexts.

4.2 Contextual Contribution

The study also contributes to research on professional service firms by examining communication capability within consultancy environments characterized by knowledge intensity and professional autonomy (von Nordenflycht, 2010; Greenwood et al., 2005). Although prior research highlights the importance of credibility, expertise articulation, and reputation in such firms (Maister, 1993), limited attention has been paid to how communication consolidates at the organizational level.

By investigating multiple consultancy firms, the study illuminates how communication practices are structured, reinforced, and recognized across different organizational settings. This contextual analysis strengthens understanding of how organizational capability processes operate within professional service environments.

4.3 Contribution Under Digital Evolution

Finally, the study contributes to emerging discussions on digital evolution and artificial intelligence in organizational contexts (Leonardi, 2011; Huang and Rust, 2021). Rather than positioning digitalization as a separate research theme, the study examines how digital developments influence the structuring, reinforcement, and recognition of communication capability. In doing so, it highlights how technological change may intensify scrutiny of communication practices and shape perceptions of communicative competence within consultancy firms.

Together, these contributions advance a more systematic understanding of communication capability as an organizational phenomenon and provide an analytically grounded framework for examining its development and recognition in digitally evolving consultancy contexts.

5. Findings and Analysis

This chapter presents the empirical findings from ten semi-structured interviews conducted across three consultancy firms: Netlight, Knowit, and Adage. The purpose of the chapter is to examine how communication practices are organized, enacted, reinforced, recognized, and shaped by digital tools in consultancy contexts. The analysis is guided by the conceptual framework developed in Chapter 2, but the empirical themes were developed inductively through iterative coding of the interview material.

The chapter does not evaluate whether communication is simply effective or ineffective. Instead, it analyses how communication appears to move, or fails to move, from individual consultant practice toward organizational capability. Organizational capability theory emphasizes that capabilities are not isolated individual skills, but recurrent and collectively sustained patterns of action embedded in routines, structures, and organizational arrangements (Nelson and Winter, 1982; Grant, 1996; Winter, 2003; Becker, 2004). This distinction is important in consultancy firms, where communication is often enacted by individual consultants in client-specific situations, yet may still depend on broader organizational systems such as mentoring, feedback, digital channels, templates, and shared norms.

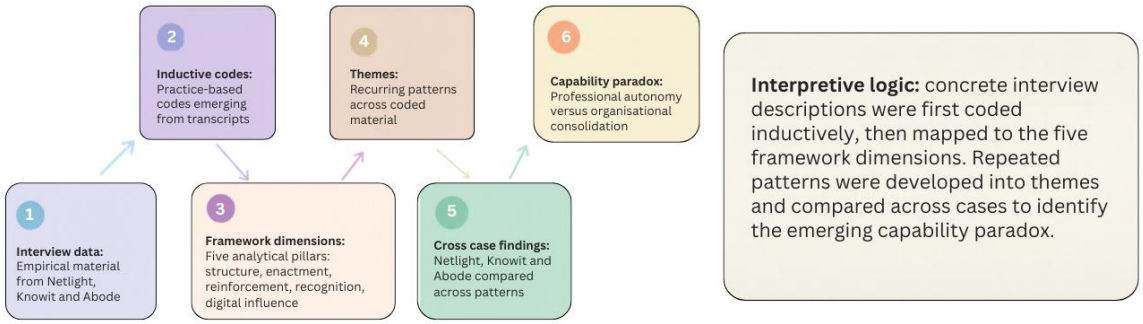


Figure 3. Analytical structure of the findings

Figure 3 illustrates how empirical material was analyzed. Interview excerpts were first coded inductively to capture practice-based patterns. These codes were then mapped to the five framework dimensions and developed into themes. The themes were compared across cases to identify cross case findings and the emerging capability paradox.

The findings show that communication is central in all three firms, but its organizational consolidation varies substantially. Communication is not absent or ignored. Rather, it is highly active, embedded in everyday work, and closely linked to project delivery, client relationships, trust, coordination, and professional identity. At the same time, communication remains unevenly structured, partly individualized, and often dependent on informal learning, relational access, and client routines. This creates the central empirical tension of the study: communication requires professional autonomy and individual judgement, but organizational capability requires consolidation beyond the individual consultant.

The chapter is organized into eight empirical findings. These findings are not presented as separate descriptions of the five framework dimensions. Instead, they show how the dimensions interact in practice. For example, documentation problems are related to structural integration, but also to collective enactment and institutional reinforcement. Similarly, identity and external attribution relate to recognition, but also to the broader tension between individual competence and organizational capability.

Table 5. Emerging themes mapped to the analytical framework

Emerging theme from coding	What the theme captures	Main framework dimension	Strongest empirical relevance
Selective structural integration	Communication structures exist, but they are unevenly located across firms, client/project, and individual levels	Structural integration	All cases
Client/project-owned communication routines	Standups, Jira boards, Teams channels, steering forums, and client documentation often structure communication more than the consultancy firm itself	Structural integration, collective enactment	Knowit, Adage
Network-supported communication	Communication works through mentors, delivery coaches, Slack communities, peers, and access to knowledgeable others	Collective enactment, institutional reinforcement	Netlight
Manager-mediated organizational connection	Managers translate central information, repeat updates, support consultants, and maintain connection between client-embedded consultants and the firm	Collective enactment, institutional reinforcement	Knowit
Informal and experiential learning	Communication is learned through feedback, observation, client exposure, mistakes, and experience rather than only through formal training	Institutional reinforcement	All cases
Documentation and codification tension	Knowledge is partly documented, but often remains difficult to locate, outdated, or dependent on individuals	Structural integration, institutional reinforcement	Knowit, Adage, Netlight
Individual versus organizational attribution	Consultants are seen both as individual experts and as representatives of the firm	Recognition and legitimacy	All cases
Recognition through effects	Communication becomes visible through trust, delivery outcomes, feedback, confusion, or breakdowns rather than formal metrics	Recognition and legitimacy	All cases
Digital enablement and fragmentation	Digital tools increase speed and access, but do not automatically create shared routines or alignment	Digital contextual influence	All cases
Cross-functional alignment bottleneck	Communication across sales, delivery, leadership, marketing, and strategy is uneven and often role-dependent	Collective enactment, structural integration	Knowit, Adage
Professional autonomy versus organizational consolidation	Consultants need flexibility and judgement, but communication capability requires shared structures and reinforcement	Cross-dimensional	All cases

5.1 Communication is selectively structured

First finding is that communication in consultancy firms is selectively structured rather than fully standardized or completely informal. Through the interviews, respondents described recurring meetings, templates, digital channels, project routines, feedback practices, onboarding material and communication artefacts. However, these structures were unevenly located. Some were owned by the

consultancy firm, some were imposed by the client or project environment, and some were managed through individual consultant judgement (see Table 6).

In Netlight, structure appeared through consultant presentation formats, mentoring, delivery coaching, feedback routines, internal courses and Slack based communities. However, communication during client delivery was not described as strongly governed by formal templates. Instead, Netlight appears to rely on a combination of recurring practices and relational support. One respondent explained that before starting an assignment, they could speak to other Netlight consultants who had worked with the same client, meet someone already at the client and use that information to prepare for the assignment. This suggests that structure exists, but it works through networks and preparation practices rather than through strict documentation.

Knowit shows a more layered pattern. At leadership and manager level, there are formal structures such as policies, onboarding material, templates, central communication, sales meetings, newsletters, management cascades and monthly one-to-one meetings. However, at consultant level, communication is often shaped by client routines. Respondents described daily standups, Teams channels, steering meetings, Jira boards, client documentation systems and project specific ways of working. This means communication can be highly structured in the project setting while the structure itself belongs mainly to the client rather than to Knowit.

Adage shows another variation. Some recurring structures exist, such as internal meetings, sales related material, team routines and client project meetings. However, respondents also described communication as strongly dependent on direct contact, senior people and knowing whom to ask. One respondent explained that internal structured capital exists in principle but is not very mature and not always useful in practice. This indicates that communication structure exists, but it is not always strong enough to carry knowledge beyond individual relationships.

The deeper pattern is therefore not absence of structure. The stronger finding is that ownership of structure is uneven. Firm owned structures support organizational consolidation. Client or project owned structures support delivery but may not strengthen the consultancy firm's own communication capability. Individual managed structures preserve flexibility but can make the organization dependent on personal judgement and availability.

Table 6. Location of communication structure across cases

Location of structure	Empirical examples	Analytical implication
Firm owned structure	Netlight mentor and delivery coach roles, internal courses, consultant presentation formats; Knowit policies, onboarding material, contract templates, monthly one-to-one meetings; Adage sales material and internal meetings	Communication is partly embedded in organizational routines, artefacts and support mechanisms
Client or project owned structure	Daily standups, Jira boards, client Teams channels, steering forums, SharePoint pages, project workshops and client documentation systems	Communication may be structured, but the structure is not necessarily owned by the consultancy firm
Individual managed structure	Personal tone, adapting technical language, knowing who to ask, direct calls to senior people, informal stakeholder management and personal message formatting	Communication remains dependent on individual consultant competence, judgement and access

This finding suggests that communication capability cannot be assessed only by the presence of templates or routines, but by where those structures are located and who owns them. Client-owned structures may support organized project communication without building the consultancy firm's own capability, while individually managed structures keep the firm dependent on personal competence. Communication moves closer to organizational capability when firm-owned structures are repeatedly enacted and reinforced.

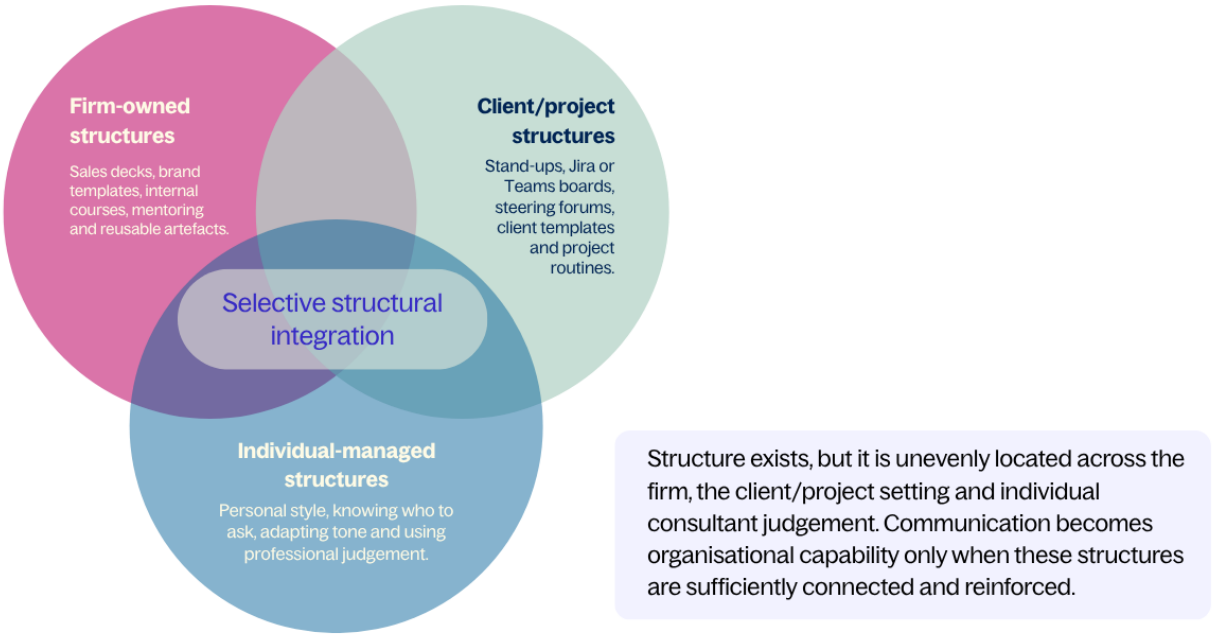


Figure 4. Three locations of communication structure

Figure 4 illustrates how communication structure is distributed across three levels: firm owned structures, client or project owned structures, and individual managed structures. The figure shows that communication is not simply structured or unstructured. Instead, structure exists unevenly across organizational artefacts, client routines, and individual consultant judgement. This supports the finding that communication is selectively structurally integrated rather than fully consolidated as an organizational capability.

5.2 Communication is enacted through networks, relationships, and local coordination

Second finding is that communication is enacted through networks, relationships and local coordination rather than through a single common organizational process. Across the cases, communication often works because people know whom to contact, which meeting to attend, which channel to use or which person can interpret a situation.

Netlight provides the strongest example of network supported communication. Respondents described Slack channels, internal communities, other Netlight consultants at the same client, mentors and delivery coaches as important resources. Before starting a new assignment, one respondent could contact other Netlighters familiar with the client, identify relevant people and gain practical knowledge before entering the project. In another example, a technical problem was solved by identifying another consultant who had worked with a similar system and booking a meeting to discuss how the issue had been handled. This suggests that communication capability is not located only in the individual

consultant, but in the network behind the consultant. This pattern resembles communities of practice, where knowledge and learning move through participation, shared practice and access to knowledgeable others rather than through formal instruction alone (Brown and Duguid, 1991; Wenger, 1998; Wenger and Snyder, 2000).

Knowit shows a more role mediated form of enactment. Communication is often carried out through managers, project leaders and client routines. Consultant managers repeat central information in one-to-one meetings, support consultants when feedback arises and help maintain the connection between client embedded consultants and the organization. Leadership communication is cascaded through management, site managers and local meetings. At consultant level, however, several respondents had limited visibility into how sales, delivery, leadership and communication align. This creates a layered case, where communication exists at several organizational levels but is not always experienced as one connected system.

Adage shows communication enacted through proximity and direct relational access. Respondents described a smaller company where people know each other, contact senior colleagues directly and solve problems through informal conversations. This supports speed and flexibility, but it also creates dependence on specific people. As the firm grows, this relational model becomes more fragile because newcomers may not know where knowledge sits or whom to ask.

The cross-case finding is that communication is collective, but collective enactment takes different forms. Netlight enacts communication through networks. Knowit enacts it through managers, leadership cascades and client project structures. Adage enacts it through direct relationships and small firm familiarity. These mechanisms are not equivalent, but they all show that communication capability depends on more than individual skill. It depends on whether communication practices are accessible, shared and repeatable across people.

Table 7. Forms of collective enactment across cases

Firm	Dominant form of collective enactment	Strength	Vulnerability
Netlight	Network based coordination through Slack, communities, mentors, delivery coaches, and peer access	Strong access to distributed knowledge and support	May depend on responsiveness, availability, and informal participation
Knowit	Project and client-based coordination through client routines and stakeholder forums	Supports delivery when client routines are clear	Internal fragmentation and weaker cross-functional alignment
Adage	People based coordination through familiarity, direct contact, and expert access	Flexible and efficient in a small firm	Fragile during growth, onboarding, and internal knowledge work

5.3 Communication capability is reinforced mainly through informal and social mechanisms

Third finding concerns how communication is learned and reinforced. Across the interviews, communication was most often described as something learned through feedback, observation, client interaction, mistakes, mentoring, senior colleagues and repeated exposure to different situations. Formal training exists in some cases, but the dominant pattern is social and experiential learning.

Netlight showed the strongest evidence of organized reinforcement. Respondents described internal courses, genuine consulting training, feedback culture, mentors, delivery coaches and peer learning. One

respondent explained that Netlight does not have a traditional manager structure in the same way but instead relies on mentors and delivery coaches who support both personal development and client delivery. This matters because communication is not left entirely to the consultant's own improvisation. It is reinforced through recurring conversations, feedback, courses and access to experienced colleagues.

Knowit shows a mixed pattern. Leadership and manager perspectives indicate that formal structures exist, including onboarding, policies, central updates, leadership communication, personal development plans, one-to-one meetings and training sessions. However, consultant perspectives show that communication is also learned through experience, client exposure and individual initiative. One consultant described learning good communication by making mistakes and seeing what worked or did not work in different client contexts. Another described that people often figure out communication through experience rather than through formal teaching. This suggests that Knowit has support mechanisms, but they are experienced differently depending on role and organizational level.

Adage also relies heavily on social learning. Respondents described learning by observing senior colleagues, receiving feedback, participating in team discussions and adapting through client work. This fits the smaller firm context, where learning often happens through proximity and direct access. However, respondents also expressed that clearer expectations and more structured support would be useful, especially when communication becomes difficult or when different people have different expectations.

Table 8. Reinforcement mechanisms identified in the empirical material

Reinforcement mechanism	Netlight	Knowit	Adage
Formal courses or workshops	Strong evidence through genuine consulting, internal courses and communication related training	Present at leadership or organizational level, but experienced unevenly by consultants	Some evidence through courses or sessions, but less systematic
Mentoring and coaching	Strong evidence through mentor and delivery coach roles	Mainly through managers and senior colleagues	Mainly through senior colleagues and direct support
Feedback culture	Strong evidence through mentor conversations, peer feedback and delivery support	Present through manager one-to-one meetings, client feedback and internal review tools	Present through performance feedback and team discussion
Learning by doing	Present	Strongly present	Strongly present
Client driven learning	Present	Strongly present	Present

The overall finding is that communication capability is reinforced across firms, but the degree of organizational institutionalization differs. Netlight shows stronger internal reinforcement through courses, mentoring, coaching, and feedback culture. Knowit relies more on client feedback and experiential learning. Adage relies on observation, feedback, and small firm social proximity. These mechanisms matter because capability development depends not only on practice, but on whether learning from practice becomes retained and reproduced in the organization (Zollo and Winter, 2002).

This finding also shows why communication capability is difficult to standardize. Communication involves tacit judgement, audience adaptation, emotional intelligence, and situational interpretation. These qualities are hard to reduce to formal templates. However, the absence of formal structure does not mean the absence of reinforcement. The empirical material suggests that communication capability is often developed socially before it becomes formally embedded.

5.4 Documentation creates a tension between codification and flexibility

Fourth finding is that documentation creates one of the clearest tensions in the data. Respondents recognized the value of documentation for onboarding, knowledge transfer, coordination and continuity. At the same time, they described documentation as difficult to maintain, difficult to locate, unevenly used or replaced by direct access to people.

In Netlight, documentation appeared in technical work and consultant profile systems, but broader communication knowledge seemed to remain more social and network based. One respondent described impact stories and consultant profiles as ways of capturing achievements, but not as a general pattern where all outcomes and communication learning are documented. Another described that most relevant knowledge can be accessed through people, Slack communities or internal networks. This makes knowledge accessible, but it remains strongly relational.

Knowit gives the richest evidence of documentation tension because the interviews include leadership, manager and consultant perspectives. Leadership described formal templates, contracts, policies and onboarding documents as important and in some cases non-negotiable. At the same time, consultants described gaps in documentation, especially around project knowledge, product guardian reviews, cross team learning and where knowledge should be stored. One respondent explained that even when they wanted knowledge to be documented so others would not depend on them, it was unclear where to put it. Another explained that knowledge often comes from being exposed to discussions with knowledgeable people, which means that only those present in the discussion receive the learning.

Adage shows the same tension in a smaller firm context. Respondents described internal SharePoint and structured capital as existing but not mature enough to function as the primary source of knowledge. Instead, employees often rely on knowing who might know. This is efficient when the company is small and people know one another, but it becomes fragile when the firm grows, when senior experts are busy or when new employees need to find information independently.

The core finding is not simply that documentation is weak. The deeper finding is that documentation sits between two competing needs (see Table 9). Codification makes knowledge accessible beyond individuals, but communication work also depends on judgement, adaptation and context. The challenge is therefore not to document everything, but to identify which communication knowledge needs to be made accessible for the organization to learn from itself.

This reflects a broader knowledge transfer problem: organizational knowledge often remains difficult to transfer when it is tacit, locally embedded or dependent on specific individuals and routines (Argote and Ingram, 2000; Szulanski, 1996; Hansen, Nohria and Tierney, 1999).

Table 9. Documentation tension across cases

Tension	Empirical expression	Capability implication
Knowledge access	Consultants often ask specific people rather than search formal systems	Knowledge remains partly individualized
Codification burden	Respondents describe documentation as tedious, unclear or difficult to place	Documentation requires ownership and routines
Knowledge freshness	Policies, onboarding material and templates need updating as work changes	Codification must be maintained to remain useful
Expert dependency	Senior or experienced people become informal sources of truth	Capability becomes vulnerable when expertise is unavailable
Onboarding challenge	New consultants may not know where to find information or who to ask	Weak codification affects transferability

The finding reveals a central paradox. Documentation can support organizational capability by making knowledge accessible beyond individual consultants. However, excessive or poorly maintained documentation can also become inefficient, outdated, or disconnected from practice. The empirical material therefore does not support a simple recommendation to document more. Instead, it shows that communication capability requires a balance between codified knowledge and relational access to expertise.

This finding is particularly important for organizational capability theory. Capabilities require stability and repeatability, but they also need to remain flexible enough to support situated action (Feldman and Pentland, 2003; Pentland and Feldman, 2005). Consultancy firms appear to resist over codification because their work depends on adaptation, autonomy, and client-specific judgement. At the same time, weak codification increases dependency on individuals and reduces the organization's ability to retain communication knowledge beyond specific people.

5.5 Consultants are perceived both as individual experts and organizational representatives

Fifth finding concerns individual versus organizational attribution. Across the cases, respondents described consultants as both individual experts and representatives of the firm. This distinction matters because communication only becomes organizational capability if it is attributed not only to the individual consultant, but also to the organization that supports them (see Table 10).

Netlight shows the strongest organizational attribution. Respondents described the individual consultant as backed by a broader Netlight network. Clients receive the consultant's personal expertise, but they also receive access to the competence, support and community behind that consultant. One respondent explained that Netlight wants clients to see both the person doing the work and the full network behind that person. This makes the organization visible through the consultant.

Knowit shows a more layered pattern. Managers and leadership described organizational identity through central communication, templates, policies, newsletters, meetings, openness and the broader Knowit brand. However, consultant interviews suggest that the client relationship can feel more immediate than the organizational relationship. One consultant explained that the client was the stakeholder they were trying to perform well for, while their manager was the closest link to Knowit.

This indicates that organizational identity exists but may be mediated through managers and internal communication rather than continuously present in daily client work.

Adage shows identity through culture, proximity and behavior. Respondents described feeling part of Adage through shared goals, events, social events, team activities and a people centered orientation. Externally, however, the consultant's individual behavior remains central. Since Adage is smaller, organizational identity appears closely tied to how individuals behave, help clients and represent the firm in practice.

The finding directly supports the capability paradox. If communication is attributed only to the individual consultant, it remains a personal competence. If clients and colleagues also see it as part of what the firm provides, communication begins to function as organizational capability. The empirical material suggests that both forms coexist. Organizational attribution becomes stronger when consultants are visibly supported by networks, managers, routines, shared identity or formal communication structures.

This is connected to organizational identity research, which shows that employees and external stakeholders attach meaning to organizations through identification, image and repeated interaction with organizational representatives (Ashforth and Mael, 1989; Dutton, Dukerich and Harquail, 1994; Hatch and Schultz, 2002).

Table 10. Individual and organizational attribution across cases

Firm	Individual attribution	Organizational attribution	Interpretation
Netlight	Personality, personal delivery and consultant expertise matter	Strong network, community and support system behind the consultant	Individual expertise is visibly supported by organizational infrastructure
Knowit	Consultants may experience client work as more immediate than organizational connection	Brand, managers, templates, newsletters, meetings and leadership communication create organizational identity	Organizational attribution is present but mediated through roles and internal structures
Adage	Personal behavior and relationships are central	Shared culture, events and people centered identity support firm belonging	Organizational identity is present but less codified

5.6 Communication is recognized through effects rather than formal metrics

A sixth finding is that communication is recognized mainly through its effects rather than through formal communication metrics. Across the interviews, respondents rarely described systematic measurement of communication capability. Instead, communication became visible when it affected trust, delivery, project progress, client perception, feedback, confusion, rework or internal morale.

In Netlight, communication was strongly linked to deliver quality and trust. One respondent described evidence of good communication as "trust and results". Communication is therefore recognized not as a separate metric, but through whether clients trust the consultant, whether work progresses and whether expectations are managed. Feedback culture also makes communication visible because consultants discuss development, delivery and client interaction with mentors, coaches and peers.

Knowit shows recognition through several channels. Leadership connects communication to strategic change, AI related urgency, policies and how messages are cascaded through the organization. Managers

recognize communication through one-to-one meetings, consultant support, interview feedback and internal updates. Consultants experience recognition more through client work, feedback, project outcomes and whether communication problems create confusion or duplication. One consultant described a case where two people could end up working on the same thing because no one had written in the channel who was doing what.

Adage shows recognition through feedback, team discussions and moments of difficulty. One respondent described receiving feedback about speaking up more in meetings. Another described communication as something that comes up in internal discussions about what the team or the company needs. This means communication is recognized, but often as part of broader professional behavior rather than as a separately named organizational capability.

Table 11. Communication Visibility Process

Visibility mechanism	Empirical expression	What it shows
Trust	Clients trust consultants when communication is clear and reliable	Communication is recognized relationally
Delivery outcomes	Projects move forward, requirements are understood and stakeholders remain aligned	Communication is recognized through performance
Feedback	Communication appears in one-to-one meetings, performance reviews, retrospectives or client feedback	Communication is recognized through reflection
Breakdowns	Confusion, duplicated work, misalignment or irritation make communication visible	Communication is recognized reactively
Organizational identity	Communication affects how consultants and firms are perceived externally	Communication is recognized as part of legitimacy

This finding has direct relevance for the second research question. Communication is recognized and valued in consultancy firms, but often indirectly. It is recognized when it affects something else: trust, results, project progress, client satisfaction, or internal alignment. This makes communication strategically important but analytically difficult to isolate. It also explains why communication may struggle to become a consolidated organizational capability. If communication is valued mainly through outcomes and breakdowns, the organization may underinvest in communication routines before problems appear.

This finding also clarifies the role of legitimacy. Communication does not become legitimate only because people say it matters. It becomes legitimate when it receives attention, resources, feedback, and reinforcement. The empirical material suggests that communication legitimacy exists but often remains implicit and outcome based rather than formally institutionalized.

5.7 Digital tools enable communication but do not automatically consolidate capability

A seventh finding is that digital tools are central to communication, but they do not automatically consolidate communication capability. Respondents described Teams, Slack, Outlook, SharePoint, Jira, GitLab, ServiceNow, PowerPoint, Claude, ChatGPT and internal AI tools. These tools support communication by enabling faster interaction, hybrid work, documentation traces, writing support, knowledge access and coordination. However, they can also reproduce fragmentation when expectations

and ownership are unclear. Digital tools also shape communication by making interaction more visible, persistent, editable and searchable, which can support coordination but also increase fragmentation when shared norms are unclear (Treem and Leonardi, 2013).

Netlight shows the strongest digitally enabled communication environment. Slack is central for asking questions, finding communities, accessing expertise and receiving updates. Teams and Outlook support meetings, while AI tools are used through organizational accounts and internal systems. In this case, digital tools reinforce an already network supported model. They are not just tools for individual productivity; they are part of how consultants access the broader organizational network.

Knowit shows a more mixed pattern. Teams, Outlook, SharePoint, PowerPoint templates and AI tools support daily communication, leadership updates, client work and internal coordination. Leadership uses tools such as Claude to prepare presentations and speed up work, while consultants rely heavily on client tools and local channels. However, awareness of policies and expectations varies. Some respondents knew that AI policies existed, while others had not looked into them. This shows that digital tools may exist at organizational level without being equally understood across roles.

Adage shows digital reliance combined with channel variation. Teams are central, but respondents also mentioned Slack, ServiceNow, email, phone calls, WhatsApp and client-specific systems. Some teams prefer messages, while others prefer calls or formal service requests. Digital tools therefore support coordination, but they also create multiple communication routes that require consultants to know which channel works for which person or team.

The empirical pattern is double sided. Digital tools enable communication, but they do not solve the organizational capability problem. They can make communication faster and more visible, but they do not automatically create shared expectations, documentation quality, cross-functional alignment or organizational recognition. Digital tools become part of communication capability only when they are embedded in shared routines and used in ways that support organizational learning.

Digital tools therefore act as both enablers and intensifiers. They enable faster communication, easier access to expertise, hybrid work, and AI assisted communication. At the same time, they can intensify expectations of responsiveness, multiply channels, and increase fragmentation. Digital tools become part of communication capability only when they are integrated into shared practices and expectations. Otherwise, they remain individual productivity tools or fragmented communication channels.

5.8 Cross-functional alignment is an emerging organizational bottleneck

An eighth finding is that cross-functional alignment remains a major bottleneck. Communication capability is not only about how consultants communicate with clients. It also concerns how sales, delivery, leadership, marketing, communication, HR and strategy align around messages, priorities, responsibilities and client needs.

This can also be understood as a boundary-spanning challenge, where communication must connect different functions, roles and external interfaces in order to support coordinated organizational action (Tushman, 1977; Ancona and Caldwell, 1992; Carlile, 2004).

Knowit provides the richest evidence for this finding because the interviews include consultants, manager and leadership perspectives. Leadership described regular sales meetings, strategy forums, management cascades and information flows through site managers and local managers. Managers described one-to-one meetings, repeated central updates and efforts to ensure that consultants receive information in a safe and understandable way. However, consultants often had limited visibility into how the wider organization aligns. One respondent described the organization as feeling like “islands”,

while another said they had no idea how sales, delivery, marketing, leadership or strategy align. This suggests that alignment may exist at some levels but is not always visible to consultants.

Adage shows a smaller firm version of the same issue. Most employees are engaged in client assignments, while internal initiatives such as sales, marketing, recruitment and knowledge sharing are often handled by whoever has time. This makes communication flexible, but it also creates unclear ownership. As the company grows, informal alignment becomes harder to sustain.

Netlight appears to handle alignment more through network density and community. Respondents described Slack channels, internal events, consultant networks, mentor relationships and delivery coaches as ways of staying connected. However, this still depends on participation in the network rather than a single formal alignment process.

Table 12. Cross-functional alignment across cases

Firm	Evidence of alignment	Evidence of bottleneck	Interpretation
Netlight	Internal communities, events, Slack channels, courses, AI month, transparency around updates	Alignment depends on participation in internal networks and culture	Relational and digital alignment mechanisms are relatively strong
Knowit	Brand material and strategic communication from group level	Delivery, sales, marketing, leadership, and strategy can be out of sync	Cross-functional alignment appears as a significant capability gap
Adage	Small size supports direct communication and shared identity	Internal work competes with client assignments, and ownership of communication is unclear	Growth increases pressure for clearer alignment mechanisms

The cross-case pattern is that communication capability requires alignment beyond the project team. A consultant may communicate well with a client, while the organization still struggles to align around sales messages, delivery expectations, documentation, market positioning or strategic change. Cross-functional alignment therefore becomes one of the clearest places where individual communication competence and organizational communication capability diverge.

5.9 Emerging communication capability configurations across cases

The findings show that communication capability does not emerge through one universal path. Instead, the same analytical framework reveals different configurations across the three firms. These configurations are not rankings or maturity levels. They show different ways in which communication becomes organizationally embedded.

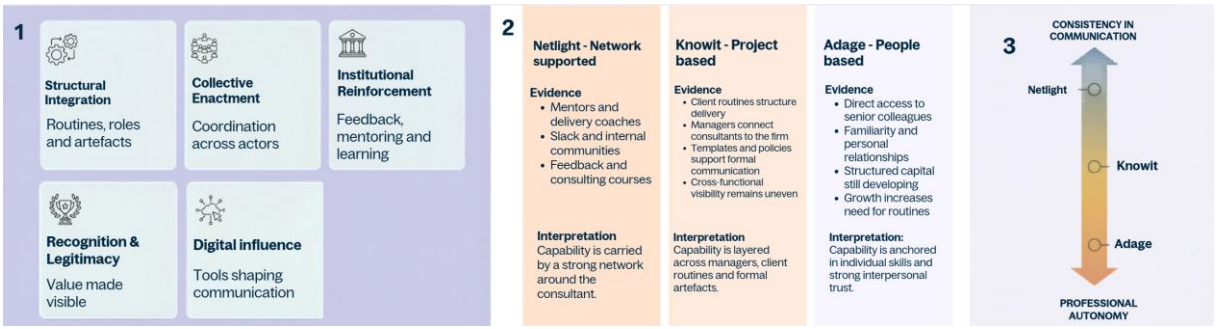


Figure 5. Framework in action: Communication capability configurations across cases

Figure 5 shows how the analytical framework was applied to the three cases. Rather than ranking the firms, it illustrates different ways communication becomes organizationally supported: a network-supported model in Netlight, a manager- and project-mediated model in Knowit, and a people-dependent model in Adage.

Netlight can be interpreted as a network supported communication capability. Communication is supported through communities, Slack channels, mentors, delivery coaches, feedback culture, internal courses and a strong sense of consultant identity. The capability lies not only in individual consultants, but in the relational and digital infrastructure around them. Netlight therefore shows that communication can be organizationally supported without being heavily formalized.

Knowit can be interpreted as a manager and client/project mediated communication capability. Communication is active and structured at several levels: leadership cascades messages, managers repeat information in one-to-one meetings, formal templates and policies exist, and client projects provide strong daily routines. However, these levels are not always experienced as one connected communication system. Consultants often rely on client routines and manager contact, while having limited visibility into wider organizational alignment. Knowit therefore shows a layered configuration rather than a simple fragmented one.

Adage can be interpreted as a people dependent communication capability under growth pressure. Communication works through familiarity, direct contact, senior expertise, shared culture and informal coordination. This can be effective in a small firm because people know one another and communication can move quickly. However, as the firm grows, this model becomes fragile. Knowledge transfer, onboarding and internal alignment require more accessible structures.

The reliance on knowing whom to ask also reflects transactive memory, where groups coordinate knowledge by understanding who holds relevant expertise rather than by storing all knowledge in one place (Wegner, 1987; Lewis, 2003; Brandon and Hollingshead, 2004).

Table 13. Case configurations through the framework

Framework dimension	Netlight	Knowit	Adage
Structural integration	Partial formal structure, supported by courses, consultant formats and recurring practices	Formal artefacts exist, but client and project routines dominate much consultant work	Limited formal structure, some routines and templates, but strong people dependency
Collective enactment	Strong network coordination through Slack, communities, mentors, delivery coaches and peers	Manager mediated and client/project mediated coordination, with uneven cross-functional visibility	Direct relational coordination through familiarity and knowing who to ask
Institutional reinforcement	Feedback culture, mentoring, internal courses, genuine consulting and delivery coaching	Managers, onboarding, one-to-one meetings, experience and client feedback	Observation, senior support, feedback and learning through experience
Recognition and legitimacy	Communication recognized through trust, delivery, feedback and network backed expertise	Recognized through feedback, manager discussions, client outcomes and leadership communication	Recognized through team discussions, performance feedback and client relationship effects
Digital contextual influence	Slack, Teams and AI tools support access, coordination and speed	Teams, Outlook, SharePoint, templates and AI tools support communication, but use varies by role	Teams, client tools, email and AI support work, but channels remain fragmented
Emerging configuration	Network supported communication capability	Manager and client/project mediated communication capability	People dependent communication capability under growth pressure

These configurations show how the framework is used in practice. The framework does not score the firms. Instead, it explains how different combinations of structure, enactment, reinforcement, recognition and digital influence produce different routes to communication capability.

5.10 The capability paradox in practice

The final and overarching finding is that the empirical material confirms the central capability paradox of the thesis. Communication in consultancy firms depends on professional autonomy, but organizational capability requires consolidation beyond individual consultants. This paradox is visible in all three firms, but it appears through different mechanisms.

The autonomy side is visible throughout the interviews. Consultants must adapt communication to clients, technical levels, project stages, personalities, stakeholder expectations and organizational cultures. They must translate expertise, manage expectations, simplify technical material, communicate uncertainty and sometimes deliver difficult messages. These tasks require judgement and cannot be fully standardized.

The consolidation side is also visible. Respondents described problems caused by missing documentation, unclear ownership, fragmented channels, inconsistent alignment, uneven feedback and reliance on specific individuals. These problems show that too much dependence on individual judgement can create organizational fragility. When communication knowledge stays with individuals,

firms struggle with onboarding, continuity, cross-functional alignment and consistent external representation.

Netlight appears to manage the paradox through network support. It preserves consultant autonomy while embedding consultants in a wider relational and digital infrastructure. Knowit appears to manage the paradox through layers of mediation: managers, leadership communication, client project routines, templates and consultant experience. However, these layers do not always connect clearly for consultants. Adage experiences the paradox through growth. Informal communication works while the firm is small but becomes more fragile as the organization grows and knowledge needs to become accessible beyond direct relationships.

Table 14. The capability paradox across cases

Firm	Autonomy side	Consolidation side	Empirical form of paradox
Netlight	Consultants adapt communication to clients, stakeholders and technical contexts	Mentors, delivery coaches, Slack communities, courses and feedback support them	Autonomy is supported through networks rather than strict rules
Knowit	Consultants adapt strongly to client routines and project contexts	Managers, leadership cascades, policies and templates provide support, but are unevenly visible	Autonomy is mediated through managers and client/project structures
Adage	Consultants communicate flexibly through personal relationships and expert access	Growth, onboarding and knowledge transfer require more structure	Autonomy works socially but becomes fragile under scale

The capability paradox does not suggest that consultancy firms should simply standardize communication. Full standardization would risk weakening the flexibility that consultancy work requires. Rather, the findings suggest that communication becomes organizational capability when individual autonomy is supported by sufficient structure, collective enactment, institutional reinforcement, recognition and digital support.

5.11 Summary of main findings

The empirical findings show that communication in consultancy firms is strategically central but unevenly consolidated as organizational capability. Communication was linked to project delivery, stakeholder alignment, client trust, internal coordination, professional identity, digital tools and organizational reputation, but the mechanisms of organizational support differ across the three cases.

Netlight shows a network supported model, reinforced through mentors, delivery coaches, Slack channels, feedback culture and community access. Knowit shows a layered and mediated model, shaped by client project routines, managers, leadership cascades, internal templates and consultant experience. Adage shows a people dependent model under pressure of growth, where communication works through direct access, familiarity and expert support, but becomes fragile as the firm expands.

Together, the findings answer RQ1 by showing that communication capability is constituted through structure, relational coordination, learning, documentation and cross-functional alignment. They answer RQ2 by showing that communication is recognized mainly through effects such as trust, feedback, project progress, client perception and breakdowns, while digital tools increase speed, access and visibility without automatically creating organizational capability.

Table 15. Summary of findings

Main finding	What it shows	Link to research questions
Communication is selectively structured	Structure exists across firm, client and individual levels	RQ1
Communication is enacted through networks, relationships and local coordination	Capability depends on networks, managers, teams and direct access	RQ1
Communication capability is reinforced mainly through informal and social mechanisms	Communication knowledge is developed through feedback, observation, experience and support	RQ1
Documentation creates a tension between codification and flexibility	Knowledge must be accessible, but communication work resists full codification	RQ1
Consultants are perceived both as individual experts and organizational representatives	External perception connects individual competence to firm representation	RQ1 and RQ2
Communication is recognized through effects rather than formal metrics	Communication becomes visible through trust, outcomes, feedback and breakdowns	RQ2
Digital tools enable communication but do not automatically consolidate capability	Tools enable speed and access but require shared routines to become capability	RQ2
Cross-functional alignment is an emerging organizational bottleneck	Organizational communication capability requires alignment beyond project teams	RQ1 and RQ2
The capability paradox is visible across cases	Communication must balance consultant autonomy with organizational consolidation	RQ1 and RQ2

The next chapter discusses these findings in relation to the literature and research questions. It examines what the findings confirm, complicate and extend in relation to organizational capability theory, communication research and professional service firm literature.

6. Discussion

This chapter discusses the empirical findings in relation to the research questions and the theoretical framework. While the Findings chapter presented the main empirical patterns, this chapter interprets what these patterns mean for understanding communication as organizational capability in consultancy firms. The discussion focuses on three analytical moves. First, it answers the two research questions directly. Second, it explains what the findings confirm, complicate and extend in relation to existing literature. Third, it develops the central theoretical contribution of the thesis: communication capability in consultancy firms emerges through a persistent tension between professional autonomy and organizational consolidation.

The discussion is structured around the capability paradox identified in the literature review. Organizational capability theory emphasizes routines, collective action and reinforcement as conditions for capability formation (Nelson and Winter, 1982; Winter, 2003; Felin and Foss, 2005). Consultancy firms, however, rely strongly on individual expertise, professional autonomy and client-specific judgement (Greenwood et al., 2005; von Nordenflycht, 2010). The empirical findings show that communication sits directly within this tension. It is central to consultancy work, but it is not always fully owned, structured or reinforced by the consultancy firm itself.

6.1 Answering RQ1: How is communication capability constituted and developed in consultancy firms?

RQ1 asked how communication capability is constituted and developed in consultancy firms. The findings suggest that it develops through structural integration, collective enactment, institutional reinforcement and case-specific organizational arrangements.

First, communication capability is partly constituted through structure, but the ownership of this structure is uneven. Structures may be firm owned, client or project owned, or individually managed. This shows that communication can be structured without being fully consolidated by the consultancy firm itself.

Second, communication capability is developed through collective enactment. Across the cases, communication was rarely performed in isolation, but through networks, managers, project teams, client stakeholders and informal relationships. Netlight showed a network supported configuration, Knowit a manager and client project mediated configuration, and Adage a people dependent configuration.

Third, communication capability is developed through social reinforcement. Consultants learn communication through feedback, observation, client exposure, experience, mentoring and repeated interaction. Formal training exists in some areas, but much learning remains informal and situated.

Overall, communication capability in consultancy firms is constituted through a layered combination of structures, relationships, learning mechanisms and digital tools. It becomes stronger when communication practices are supported by shared routines, accessible knowledge, feedback systems, organizational identity and cross-functional alignment.

Table 16. Answer to RQ1

Aspect of communication capability	What the findings show	Implication
Structural integration	Structure exists, but is unevenly located across firm, client and individual levels	Communication capability depends on who owns and maintains the structure
Collective enactment	Communication is enacted through networks, managers, project teams and local coordination	Capability requires shared access to people, knowledge and coordination mechanisms
Institutional reinforcement	Communication is learned through feedback, observation, mentoring, experience and client exposure	Capability develops socially, but may remain uneven if reinforcement is informal
Documentation and knowledge access	Knowledge is partly documented, but often remains difficult to locate or dependent on individuals	Capability remains fragile when communication knowledge is not accessible beyond people
Case configuration	Netlight, Knowit and Adage show different routes to communication capability	Capability is not one universal model, but develops through different organizational configurations

6.2 Answering RQ2: How is communication capability recognized and valued, and how do digital developments shape this recognition?

RQ2 asked how communication capability is recognized and valued within consultancy firms, and how digital developments shape this recognition. The findings show that communication is recognized mainly through its effects rather than formal metrics. It becomes visible when it affects trust, project progress, client relationships, stakeholder alignment, feedback, confusion, rework or organizational identity.

This means that communication is valued, but often indirectly. Respondents rarely describe formal communication measurements. Instead, good communication was recognized through client trust, project progress, understood requirements, positive feedback or avoided problems. Poor communication became visible through misalignment, duplicated work, misunderstood responsibilities, wrong channels or missing documentation.

This partly confirms communication evaluation literature, which argues that communication value is difficult to isolate because its outcomes are relational, indirect and distributed across organizational processes (Meng and Berger, 2012; Zerfass, Verčič and Volk, 2017). However, the findings extend this literature by showing that in consultancy firms, communication recognition is strongly tied to professional performance and client trust.

Digital tools shape this recognition by making communication faster, more visible and easier to trace, but they may also fragment communication when platforms, expectations or information ownership are unclear. Tools therefore support communication capability only when embedded in shared routines and expectations.

AI tools are also becoming part of the communication environment, especially for drafting, summarizing, preparing presentations, rewriting, structuring ideas and accessing information. However,

AI supports communication tasks rather than replacing the need for judgement, trust, stakeholder interpretation and organizational alignment.

Table 17. Answer to RQ2

Recognition mechanism	Empirical meaning	Implication
Trust	Communication is valued when clients and colleagues trust the consultant	Communication becomes visible through relationships
Delivery outcomes	Communication is recognized when work progresses and expectations are met	Communication value is tied to project performance
Feedback	Communication appears in manager meetings, client feedback, retrospectives and performance discussions	Communication is reinforced through reflection
Breakdowns	Communication becomes visible when confusion, duplication or misalignment occurs	Recognition is often reactive
Digital traceability	Digital tools make communication more visible and searchable	Visibility increases, but capability still requires shared routines
AI support	AI helps with drafting, structuring and summarizing communication	AI supports tasks, but does not replace communication judgement

6.3 What the findings confirm from existing theory

The findings confirm several assumptions from organizational capability theory. First, they support the idea that organizational capability requires more than individual competence. In all three cases, skilled consultants were able to communicate effectively, but this did not automatically mean that communication was organizationally consolidated. This confirms the distinction between individual skills and organizational capabilities (Winter, 2003; Felin and Foss, 2005).

Second, the findings confirm that routines and repeated practices matter. Recurring meetings, onboarding processes, templates, manager conversations, feedback routines, Slack channels and project rituals all helped stabilize communication practices. These findings align with routines literature, which emphasizes that organizational capabilities are grounded in recurrent and recognizable patterns of action (Nelson and Winter, 1982; Becker, 2004; Pentland and Feldman, 2005).

Third, the findings confirm that learning and reinforcement are central to capability development. Communication capability was not created only through formal templates, but through feedback, mentoring, observation, client experience and repeated practice. This supports the view that capabilities develop through learning and reinforcement over time (Zollo and Winter, 2002).

Fourth, the findings confirm professional service firm literature by showing that consultancy work depends heavily on expert judgement, client trust and individual consultant performance. Respondents repeatedly described the need to adapt communication to different stakeholders, technical levels, client situations and project stages. This aligns with research on professional service firms, where value creation depends on expert discretion and credibility (Greenwood et al., 2005; von Nordenflycht, 2010).

6.4 What the findings complicate or challenge

The findings also complicate existing theory in several ways. Organizational capability theory often emphasizes routines, structures and organizational integration, but the empirical material shows that communication capability in consultancy firms does not always develop through formalization. In Netlight, communication appeared strongly supported by networks, community, mentoring and Slack based access rather than strict documentation or formal communication procedures. This suggests that communication capability can be organizationally supported through relational infrastructure, not only through formal routines.

The findings also complicate the assumption that structure is necessarily firm owned. In consultancy firms, much of the structure surrounding communication may come from the client. Client routines, project boards, standups, steering forums and documentation systems often organize the consultant's daily communication. This means that a consultant may operate in a highly structured communication environment while the consultancy firm itself may not own that structure. This is important because capability theory usually focuses on what the firm can reproduce internally, while consultancy firms often depend on structures located partly outside their organizational boundary.

The findings further complicate communication evaluation literature. Communication was clearly valued but not always measured or formally named. It was recognized through trust, delivery, feedback and breakdowns. This suggests that communication capability may be important even when it lacks formal measurement systems. The absence of formal metrics does not mean communication lacks value, but it may make the capability harder to reinforce and legitimize.

Finally, the findings challenge a simple digitalization argument. Digital tools increased speed, visibility and access, but they did not automatically produce communication capability. In some cases, digital tools supported coordination; in others, they created fragmentation across channels or uncertainty about where information should be stored. This supports sociomaterial perspectives, where technology shapes practice but does not determine organizational capability by itself (Orlikowski, 2007; Leonardi, 2011).

6.5 Case configurations as different routes to communication capability

The main extension of the thesis is the argument that communication capability in consultancy firms develops through a capability paradox. Communication must remain flexible, individualized and context sensitive because consultants work with different clients, stakeholders and technical problems. At the same time, communication must become sufficiently structured, shared, reinforced and recognized to exist beyond individual consultants.

This extends organizational capability theory by showing that capability formation in consultancy firms may not always mean stronger formalization. Instead, communication capability may be supported through different configurations. Netlight shows a network supported route, where capability is carried through communities, mentors, coaches, feedback and digital networks. Knowit shows a manager and client project mediated route, where capability is shaped by leadership cascades, managers, client routines and consultant experience. Adage shows a dependent route under growth pressure, where capability is flexible but fragile because knowledge and coordination rely strongly on individuals.

The thesis also extends communication research by shifting attention from communication effectiveness to communication consolidation. Instead of asking only whether communication works, the study asks whether communication becomes something the organization can support, reproduce and recognize. This helps connect communication research to organizational capability theory.

The thesis further extends professional service firm literature by showing that communication is one of the mechanisms through which the tension between professional autonomy and organizational coordination becomes visible. Consultants need autonomy to communicate effectively in client settings, but too much reliance on individual autonomy makes communication difficult to stabilize at firm level.

Table 18. What the study confirms, complicates and extends

Relationship to theory	Discussion point	Contribution
Confirms	Capabilities require more than individual competence	Communication must be examined beyond personal communication skill
Confirms	Routines and reinforcement matter	Templates, feedback, mentoring and recurring practices support communication capability
Complicates	Capability does not always develop through formalization	Network and manager mediated support can also consolidate communication
Complicates	Structure may be client owned rather than firm owned	Consultancy capability is shaped by structures outside the firm boundary
Challenges	Digital tools do not automatically create capability	Tools support communication only when embedded in shared routines
Extends	Communication capability develops through a paradox	Autonomy and organizational consolidation must coexist

6.6 The capability paradox as the central theoretical contribution

The central theoretical contribution of the thesis is the identification of communication capability as a paradoxical organizational phenomenon in consultancy firms. Communication is strategically central because consultants create value through expertise articulation, client engagement, trust building and stakeholder alignment. However, the same professional autonomy that enables effective communication also makes communication difficult to standardize, document and reproduce.

This paradox appears differently across the cases. Netlight manages the paradox through network support. Consultants retain autonomy, but are embedded in communities, Slack channels, mentors, delivery coaches and feedback systems. Knowit manages the paradox through layered mediation. Consultants rely on client routines and manager contact, while leadership and central functions provide templates, policies and strategic messages. Adage experiences the paradox through growth. Informal communication works well in a small firm but becomes fragile when knowledge needs to move beyond direct relationships.

The paradox therefore should not be understood as a problem that can be solved by standardizing communication completely. Full standardization would undermine the flexibility needed in consultancy work. At the same time, leaving communication entirely to individual consultants makes the organization vulnerable to fragmentation, knowledge loss and inconsistent client representation. Communication capability emerges between these two poles.

6.7 Refining the analytical framework

The empirical findings support the five dimensions of the analytical framework, but they also suggest that the dimensions should be understood as interacting rather than separate. Structural integration, collective enactment, reinforcement, recognition and digital influence overlap in practice.

For example, documentation tension is not only a structural issue. It also affects learning, onboarding and knowledge sharing. Individual versus organizational attribution is not only about recognition. It also affects collective enactment, because clients may or may not see the wider firm behind the individual consultant. Digital tools are not only a separate contextual factor. They shape structure, coordination, documentation and recognition at the same time.

The framework therefore remains useful, but the findings suggest that it should be applied as an interpretive lens rather than as a checklist. Its value lies in helping identify where communication is supported, where it remains individualized and how different organizational mechanisms interact.

Table 19. Framework refinement from empirical findings

Framework dimension	Empirical refinement
Structural integration	Structure should be analyzed by ownership: firm owned, client owned or individual managed
Collective enactment	Communication may be enacted through networks, managers, client routines or direct relationships
Institutional reinforcement	Reinforcement may be formal, but is often social and experiential
Recognition and legitimacy	Communication is recognized mainly through effects rather than formal metrics
Digital contextual influence	Digital tools support communication, but may also fragment it if routines are unclear
Cross dimensional insight	The dimensions interact through the tension between autonomy and consolidation

6.8 Summary of the discussion

This discussion has shown that communication capability in consultancy firms is neither purely individual nor fully organizational. It emerges through the interaction between consultant autonomy and organizational consolidation. The findings confirm that routines, reinforcement and recognition matter for capability development, but they also complicate capability theory by showing that communication capability can be supported through networks, managers, client routines and relational infrastructure rather than formal structures alone.

The main contribution of the thesis is therefore the concept of communication capability as a paradoxical organizational phenomenon in consultancy firms. Communication must remain flexible enough to support professional judgement and client adaptation, while becoming sufficiently structured, shared, reinforced and recognized to exist beyond individual consultants. This tension provides the basis for the conclusion chapter.

7. Conclusion

This thesis examined how communication becomes an organizational capability in consultancy firms. The study shows that communication is not simply an individual skill or support activity. It is central to how consultants translate expertise, coordinate work, build trust and represent the firm. However, communication does not automatically become organizational capability just because it is important. It becomes capability only when it is supported beyond the individual consultant.

7.1 Main conclusions and contribution

In response to RQ1, the findings show that communication capability is constituted through shared structures, collective practices, reinforcement mechanisms and accessible knowledge. Across cases, communication was structured through a mix of firm owned routines, client or project practices and individual consultant judgement. Netlight showed a network supported configuration, Knowit a manager and client mediated configuration, and Adage a people dependent configuration under growth pressure.

In response to RQ2, communication was recognized mainly through its effects rather than through formal metrics. It became visible through trust, delivery outcomes, feedback, client perception, confusion or rework. Digital tools and AI-supported communication by increasing speed, access and visibility, but they did not automatically create organizational capability. Their value depended on whether they were connected to shared routines, ownership and expectations.

The main contribution of the thesis is the concept of communication capability as a capability paradox. Consultancy communication required professional autonomy and situated judgement, while organizational capability requires structure, reinforcement, recognition and consolidation beyond individuals. The thesis therefore contributes an analytical explanation of how communication moves between individual competence and organizational capability.

7.2 Practical implications

For consultancy firms, the findings suggest that communication capability cannot be strengthened only by adding more tools, templates or communication channels. Firms need to understand where communication knowledge is located, who reinforces it, and whether it can be accessed beyond specific individuals. Selected routines, clearer documentation, feedback practices, onboarding support and cross-functional alignment can strengthen communication capability without reducing professional flexibility.

The findings also show that communication structure should be examined in relation to where it is located. If the structure comes from clients or individual consultants, the firm may remain dependent on external routines and personal judgement. Communication capability can therefore be strengthened by making selected practices more visible, reusable and accessible, while avoiding excessive standardization.

Documentation is another important implication. Rather than treating documentation only as an administrative task, consultancy firms should approach it as part of organizational learning. Weak documentation creates dependency on individuals and makes onboarding harder, while useful and reusable knowledge can support socialization, continuity and knowledge transfer (van Maanen and Schein, 1979).

Managers, mentors and coaches also play an important role as carriers of communication capability. They translate information, provide feedback, support consultants and maintain organizational connections. Clear feedback mechanisms can also support psychological safety by allowing consultants

to raise uncertainty, ask questions and discuss communication problems before they become delivery issues (Edmondson, 1999).

The findings further suggest that firms should clarify expectations around digital tools, AI and cross-functional alignment. Communication capability depends not only on consultant-client interaction, but also on alignment between sales, delivery, leadership, marketing, communication and strategy. Digital tools can support this alignment, but only when they are connected to shared routines, ownership and expectations.

The study also has social and economic sustainability relevance. Clearer communication practices can reduce ambiguity, support newcomer integration, improve knowledge sharing and reduce duplicated work. In knowledge-intensive firms, this can contribute to healthier work environments and more efficient use of expertise.

7.3 Limitations and future research

Several limitations should be acknowledged. The study is based on a qualitative multiple case design with a limited number of interviews, which means that the findings are not statistically generalizable. The contribution is instead analytical, offering insight into how communication capability appears across selected consultancy contexts.

The cases also differ in access and depth. Knowit is the primary case and includes several organizational perspectives, while Netlight and Adage provide useful but more limited comparative material. The cross-case analysis should therefore be interpreted as exploratory rather than definitive.

The researcher's partial insider position in relation to Knowit provided access and contextual understanding but also required reflexive attention to possible bias. This risk was addressed through systematic coding, cross-case comparison and grounding the interpretation in interview material. However, the researcher's position should still be recognized as part of the research context.

Another limitation is that the study relies on participants' retrospective descriptions. Some taken-for-granted communication practices may therefore have been difficult to articulate, especially because communication often becomes visible only when it breaks down.

Future research could examine more consultancy firms, national contexts and consultancy domains. Longitudinal studies could explore how communication capability develops as firms grow, formalize routines or introduce new digital and AI-supported tools. Future research could also investigate how gender, role and seniority influence how communication is perceived and valued, particularly regarding tone, audience adaptation, body language and attention to detail, which appeared in the material but were not systematically analyzed.

Overall, the thesis concludes that communication becomes organizational capability when individual judgement is supported by shared structures, collective practices, reinforcement, recognition and digital support. The challenge is not to remove consultant autonomy, but to make communication reliable beyond the individual consultant.

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9. AI Use Disclosure

AI-supported tools, including ChatGPT, were used during the thesis process as auxiliary support for language refinement, structural development, summarizing draft material, improving clarity, and developing alternative ways of presenting tables, figures and arguments. AI was also used to support reflection on the coding workbook, codebook refinement, theme organization and presentation of empirical findings.

AI-generated suggestions related to codes, themes or findings were treated as preliminary analytical support and were reviewed against the interview transcripts, coding workbook and research questions before being retained. The final interpretation of empirical material, selection of findings, theoretical argumentation and conclusions remain the responsibility of the author.

AI was not used to generate interview data, fabricate empirical material or create unsupported references. All academic references included in the thesis were checked by the author to ensure that they correspond to real publications and are relevant to the arguments made in the text.

10. Appendices

Appendix A: Interview guide

The following interview guide was used to conduct semi-structured interviews with participants across consultancy firms. The questions were designed to elicit concrete, experience-based responses related to day-to-day communication practices, including internal coordination, client interaction, and organizational support mechanisms. They were iterated and tested throughout the process.

The guide followed a flexible structure, allowing the interviewer to adapt question order and use follow-up probes depending on the participant's responses. This approach enabled deeper exploration of emerging themes while maintaining consistency across interviews.

Introduction (shared with participants)

Thank you for taking the time to speak with me. This interview is part of a master's thesis exploring how communication practices work in consultancy firms. The focus is on understanding how communication is organized, coordinated, and experienced in day-to-day work.

The interview will focus on your experiences, and there are no right or wrong answers. With your consent, the interview will be recorded and used for analysis in an anonymized form.

Questions:

1. Can you describe your role and the kinds of communication that are part of your work?
2. Can you walk me through a recent piece of work or project and how communication was involved from start to finish?
    a. Who needed to be involved or kept aligned?
    b. Where did communication work well?
    c. Where did it become difficult?
3. Can you walk me through how communication is organized in your day-to-day work, including any routines, tools, templates, or documentation you use?
    a. What usually gets documented, and what tends to stay with individuals?
    b. Can you describe a situation where documentation would have helped but was missing?
    c. Why do you think some things are not documented, even when they might be useful later?
4. When several people, teams, or functions are involved in the same work, how is communication coordinated?
    a. How do sales, delivery, marketing/communication, leadership, or strategy align with each other?
    b. Can you describe a situation where this alignment worked well?
    c. Can you describe a situation where it was out of sync?
5. What different ways of communicating have you seen across teams, roles, or situations in the organization?
    a. What do you think explains these differences?
    b. How does this affect the work?
    c. What would someone new to the organization not immediately understand?
6. How do people here learn what good communication looks like in practice?
    a. Is it mostly learned through experience, feedback, observation, or formal support?
    b. What kind of support, guidance, or follow-up have you experienced?
    c. What would a new consultant struggle with at first?
7. In what situations does communication get talked about, recognized, or evaluated in the organization?
    a. What counts as evidence that communication is working well?
    b. Is communication discussed mainly when things go wrong, or also when things go well?
    c. How is good communication noticed in feedback, project reviews, or client relationships?
8. When clients or external stakeholders interact with consultants from your firm, how do you think they perceive them - more as individual experts, or as representatives of the organization?
    a. What makes the organization’s identity visible in communication?
    b. How do people learn the firm’s tone, style, or way of presenting itself?
    c. Can you describe a situation where individual style mattered more than organizational identity?
9. Can you walk me through how digital tools are part of communication in your work, and how they shape what is expected from people?
    a. Are AI tools used individually, or is there organizational guidance?
    b. Do tools make communication clearer, faster, more fragmented, or more demanding?
    c. Are there shared expectations around tools like Teams, Slack, SharePoint, Copilot, or ChatGPT?
10. What kinds of communication challenges or difficult trade-offs come up in your work?
    a. Can you describe a situation where more structure would have helped?
    b. Can you describe a situation where too much structure would have made communication less effective?
    c. How do people balance flexibility with consistency?
11. What have I not asked that would help me understand how communication works here?

Appendix B: Codebook

The empirical material was coded using an iterative approach. An initial set of inductive codes was developed after the first interview and subsequently refined as additional interviews were analyzed. Codes were merged, renamed, or adjusted when similar patterns appeared across cases. In parallel, each code was mapped to one of the five framework dimensions: structural integration, collective enactment, institutional reinforcement, recognition and legitimacy, and digital influence. The full coding workbook was used as an internal analysis tool, while the excerpt below illustrates how the final codebook was structured.

The selected codes in Table 20 are representative examples from the refined codebook. They were chosen because they cover the main framework dimensions and reflect several central patterns that emerged across the interviews, including selective structuring, documentation tension, cross-functional alignment, informal learning, organizational attribution, and digital guidance.

Table 20. Excerpt from the refined codebook

Refined inductive code	Definition	Include when	Exclude when	Related framework dimension
Selective standardization	Communication is structured in some areas through templates, routines, or artefacts, but not consistently across all work contexts.	The participant describes templates, recurring routines, standardized consultant presentations, proposal formats, or reusable communication artefacts.	Do not use it when the structure mainly comes from the client organization, or when the participant describes a complete lack of guidance.	Structural integration
Documentation and codification tension	Communication related knowledge is partly documented, but important knowledge often remains difficult to locate, unevenly updated, or dependent on individuals.	The participant describes missing documentation, unclear storage locations, outdated material, or the need to ask specific people for knowledge that could have been documented.	Do not use it when the issue is mainly about digital tool choice or general information overload without reference to documentation or knowledge storage.	Structural integration
Cross-functional alignment and ownership	Communication across functions, such as sales, delivery, marketing, leadership, or strategy, requires coordination but lacks clear ownership or consistent alignment.	The participant describes coordination challenges between functions, unclear responsibility for messages, or situations where different parts of the organization are not aligned.	Do not use for ordinary team coordination within one project unless the issue clearly involves multiple organizational functions.	Collective enactment
Informal and experiential learning	Communication practices are learned mainly through experience, observation, feedback, mistakes, or client interaction rather than through formal training.	The participant describes learning by doing, observing senior colleagues, receiving feedback, adapting to client situations, or learning from mistakes.	Do not use when the participant describes structured courses, formal onboarding, or planned communication training as the main mechanism.	Institutional reinforcement
Organizational identity and brand representation	Communication shapes whether consultants are perceived as individual experts or as representatives of the firm.	The participant discusses firm tone, brand identity, external representation, client perception, or whether the organization is visible through consultants' behavior.	Do not use for general client communication unless the answer explicitly concerns organizational identity, attribution, or representation.	Recognition and legitimacy
AI governance and organizational guidance	The organization provides rules, expectations, or internal systems for how AI tools should be used in communication or work practices.	The participant describes internal AI tools, rules for AI use, organizational accounts, approved tools, or guidance on what can and cannot be shared with AI systems.	Do not use when AI is only mentioned as an individual productivity tool without organizational guidance or governance.	Digital influence

This codebook excerpt illustrates how the analysis moved from empirical observations to more stable analytical categories. The codes remained inductive in the sense that they were developed from the interview material, but they were organized deductively through the five framework dimensions. This enabled comparison across cases while still allowing new empirical themes to emerge from the data.

Appendix C: Example of Coding Process

To illustrate how the empirical material was analyzed, Table 21 presents an example of how a single interview excerpt was coded and interpreted.

Table 21. Example of coding process

Interview excerpt	Inductive code	Framework dimension	Theme	Analytical interpretation
"It's very people dependent and not very process dependent"	People dependent communication	Structural integration and collective enactment	Informal communication model under scaling pressure	Communication is not embedded in formal organizational routines but relies on individual expertise, which may create challenges as the organization grows